Every Favour a Debt

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A Novel

Every Favour a Debt

A work of fiction. Names, characters, places and incidents are products of the imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, is entirely coincidental.

For adult readers.

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Chapter One

The Dedication

. . .

She is early, because to be late in this city is to be read as careless, and careless women are charged more for everything. The morning is still blue at the edges. Below the Caelian the streets are already loud with handcarts and muleteers swearing at the gradient, with slaves carrying water up from the fountains in jars that knock against their hips. Antonia Cassia stands in her own courtyard and puts her hand, quite flat, to the painted plaster to feel whether the damp has come through again in the night. It has. A bloom of cold under the red. She makes a note of it in the part of her mind where repairs live, between the price of Falernian and the name of the fuller who does not steal.

Diomedes is waiting with the tablets. He does not look at her face first. He looks at her hands, as clerks do, to see if she is ready to hold a stylus or only to listen. “The dedication crowds will close the Forum by the third hour,” he says. “If the wine is to come up from the warehouses today it must come now.”

“Then now,” she says. “And pay the carter before he unloads, not after. I am tired of his face at the kitchen door.”

He marks it. The wax takes the point with a small, neat resistance that she has always liked. Everything in this house should resist a little before it yields. The doors. The accounts. The women, when a guest mistakes payment for ownership. Herself, most of all, when she is asked a question whose answer would be useful to the asker.

Eirene comes across the courtyard with a bowl of warm water and a cloth over her arm, her hair still pinned for sleep. She is Antonia's age and has the particular beauty of women who have stopped arranging their faces for other people before noon. “You have ink on your jaw,” Eirene says.

“Then I was working in my sleep.”

“You were working instead of it.” Eirene wipes the mark away. Her fingers are cool. “The new hanging is here. The embroiderer herself brought it. She would not give it to the porter.”

“Good for her. Give her breakfast and keep her from Barbatus. He thinks courtesy is a kind of wrestling.”

Diomedes turns a tablet over. “There is also a notice. From the aediles' office. It was left before dawn, which is either diligence or a wish not to be seen leaving it.”

Antonia takes it. The seal is correct. The hand is a clerk's hand, trained to make threats look like administration. An inspection. A review of contributions, of registrations, of the uses to which rooms in this insula are put after dark. Words that have been washed so often they no longer smell of anything: order, decency, precedent. At the foot, a name cited as proposing the review to the Senate's committee. She reads it twice, not because she doubts her eyes but because her eyes, at thirty-eight, prefer close work in better light, and because she wants the small delay in which a feeling can be put down somewhere it will not be seen.

Gnaeus Cornelius Lentulus.

Eirene is watching her. Diomedes is very interested in the courtyard roses, which are overwatered and know it.

“Well,” Antonia says. “The emperor dedicates a forum today, and Lentulus dedicates himself to my drains. We all build what we can.”

She hands the notice back. “File it with the tax receipts. Answer nothing today. If a man sends a clerk before dawn he wants a reply before noon, and I have never yet let Lentulus set the hour in my house.”

■

He is being shaved when his son comes in, which means he cannot turn his head, which means his son must say whatever he has come to say to a profile held still by another man's hand. Gnaeus Cornelius Lentulus

has found, over twenty years of public life, that a razor at the throat improves the quality of other people's sentences. They become shorter. They become, if not honest, at least economical.

“The Forum today,” the boy says. He is twenty and calls this an opening.

“Yes.”

“Shall I ride with you or with Uncle Postumus?”

“With me. Postumus will talk through the sacrifices and then claim he foresaw the omens.”

The barber's thumb pulls the skin taut under his jaw. In the mirror — polished bronze, his grandfather's, the rim dented where a slave dropped it the winter the Tiber froze at the edges — Lentulus can see his son shift from foot to foot in a way that his tutors were paid to correct and did not. The boy has his mother's height and, Lentulus thinks, with the clarity that comes when one may not move, none of his mother's patience and all of his own appetite for being elsewhere.

“There is talk,” the boy says, “about your proposal. The inspections.”

“There is always talk. It is the city's second water supply.”

“They say it is aimed. At one house in particular.”

The razor pauses. The barber, who has shaved three consuls and buried two, knows when a household has stepped on its own hem.

“Who are they, Marcus?” Lentulus asks.

“Men at the baths. Men who owe me money at dice and pay in information because it is cheaper.”

“A proposal on registrations is aimed at everyone who has failed to register. If one house feels it more than others, that may be because one house has grown very large on very small paperwork.” He can hear how well this will sound in the Senate, and how thin it sounds here, with soap on his neck. “You will not repeat bath-house talk at the dedication. You will stand where you are put, you will be seen to attend to the emperor, and you will remember that your sister's negotiations require this family to look like a wall, not a window.”

Marcus bows, correctly, which in this family is what young men do instead of slamming doors the slaves would have to repair.

When he has gone, the barber resumes. “Shall I leave the scar, dominus?”

The scar is small, under the left ear, older than the boy who just left the room. Lentulus says, “You always leave the scar, Felix. It is not a decision I need to make fresh each morning.”

“No, dominus.” Felix wipes the blade. “Some men like to think it is.”

Out in the atrium the ancestral masks look down from their cupboards, wax faces darkened by smoke and time, each with its painted inscription: offices held, triumphs voted, provinces governed. Lentulus passes them as he passes them every morning, with the brief, involuntary arithmetic of the living: what he has added, what he has merely maintained, what the debts secured against the Campanian estates would look like if debts were inscribed under a man's name as offices are. He touches nothing. A Cornelius does not touch the masks for luck. He behaves as if luck were a vulgarity other families require.

His wife is at the household shrine, making the morning offering with the household gathered in the order she has arranged and rearranged over nineteen years until it looks like nature. Servilia does not look up when he joins her. She pours, she speaks the words, she sets the cup down exactly within the ring its predecessors have left on the stone. Only when the slaves have withdrawn does she say, “You sent the notice before dawn.”

“The aediles sent it. I proposed a review. These are distinct actions.”

“In the Senate they will be. At dinner they will not.” She straightens the fold of his toga where it crosses his chest. Her hands are expert and entirely without tenderness, which is not the same as without care. “If you mean to make war on that woman, Lentulus, do it in daylight and win it quickly. This family has a daughter to marry. We cannot afford a siege that everyone in Rome watches while eating.”

“I do not make war on women,” he says.

"No," Servilia says. "You make proposals. Rome will supply the war."

■

By the third hour the new Forum is a press of white wool and oiled hair and January sun striking gilding fit to blind a man into piety. Trajan moves through his own magnificence like a surveyor who happens to own the land: a soldier-emperor among columns, basilicas, libraries rising in Greek and Latin on either side of a courtyard where a column will stand when the carvers have finished telling the Dacian wars in a spiral no one at ground level will ever fully read. Antonia, who has no business being seen at an imperial dedication and every business seeing it, stands at the margin with Eirene and a veil drawn in the respectable style, in the company of contractors' wives and a dealer in purple dye who owes her money and is therefore delighted to make room.

She does not look for Lentulus. This is a discipline, like not touching a loose tooth. She looks instead at the stone-cutters' marks still visible on a base course, at a secretary of the emperor's household she knows to be short-sighted and vain about it, at the way the crowd makes a lane for men it believes important and closes, just as instinctively, against men it has finished with. Power in Rome is mostly this: a lane opening.

It opens, inevitably, not far from her. Senators in their broad stripes. A priest with his cap tied under his chin. And Lentulus, in the fold and fall of wool that costs more than a good horse, listening to the emperor with his head inclined at the angle that, in their youth — she puts the thought down, hard, like a cup that might spill — that men of his family are taught before they are taught Greek. He is forty-five. There is grey now at his temples that the barber cannot shave away. It suits him, which she notes as she would note a competitor's new cook: professionally, and with resentment held at a distance where it can be of use.

He sees her. Of course he sees her. Twenty years of not speaking in public requires a highly developed awareness of where the other person is standing.

Neither of them inclines a head. The crowd shifts. A child on his father's shoulders points at the equestrian statue and shrieks with the pure, unpatronised joy of a person who does not yet know what anything costs. Somewhere a trumpet tests the air and the pigeons rise off the new marble in a single grey applause.

Eirene says, very quietly, “The embroiderer is still at the house. She asked whether the mistress pays by the piece or by the day, and when Diomedes said by the piece she said, good, because her days belong to her father. I liked her for it.”

“Pay her by the piece,” Antonia says, still looking at the Forum, at the lane closing now behind the senators. “And then add a day's wage, and write it in the book as thread. If her days belong to her father, we will not be the ones to inform him that her work is worth more than he thinks. Let her tell him herself, when she is ready.”

She turns before the sacrifices begin. She has a house to run, an inspection to outlive, and a long-practised conviction that the gods, like senators, prefer to be addressed by people who have first attended to their drains.

Chapter Two

Registrations

. . .

The inspector arrives at the hour when respectable houses are still receiving clients and houses like hers are changing the flowers. He is a man in his thirties with a clerk and a measuring rod and the careful blankness of someone who has been told, by a person who outranks him, that this inspection matters, and told, by a person who pays him, that it would be a shame if it mattered too much. Antonia receives him in the small dining room, not the great one. She has learned to size a room to a man's self-regard: too large and he must fill it, too small and he must escape it.

“You keep a lodging house,” he says, “with dining.”

“I keep a house,” she says, “where men of business may dine in private and hear music. The registrations are there.” Diomedes lays them out like a hand of cards he expects to win with: names, fees, the tax paid quarterly and stamped, the licence for the sale of wine, the lease of the premises from an owner in Ostia who has never, in eleven years, inquired what music is playing so long as the rent arrives before the Kalends.

The inspector runs a finger down the column of women's names. Each name is a legal condition before it is a person: freedwoman, freeborn, citizen, alien. Each has a fee against it. Rome taxes what it condemns with an efficiency it brings to few of its virtues, and Antonia pays the tax on the day, in full, in coin that rings. She has always paid. A woman in her position who cheats the treasury is a story; a woman who overpays it slightly, through rounding, is a footnote, and footnotes survive.

“And this one?” The finger stops. “Daphne. No family name.”

“Daphne, freedwoman of Gaius Antonius, manumitted three years ago before witnesses whose names Diomedes can supply. She sings. She also plays the lyre indifferently, which we do not register, out of kindness.”

The clerk writes. The rod measures a doorway and finds it a doorway. In the corridor, one of the kitchen boys drops a tray and the crash arrives in the small dining room as a useful reminder that this is a working house and not a proposition. The inspector, to his credit, does not flinch. He is looking, Antonia sees, for the thing he has been sent to find, and beginning to understand that if it exists it will not be written in the book she keeps for inspectors, nor in the second book either — the one Diomedes keeps for her — but in the third accounting, which is her memory, and which does not admit measuring rods.

“There have been complaints,” he says at last. “Noise. Congregation. Men of senatorial rank seen leaving after the second watch.”

“Men of senatorial rank leave the Senate after dark too, in the winter. I believe the streets survive it.” She pours him watered wine herself, which is a courtesy and also a way of ending a sentence. “Record the complaint. Record also that the neighbours on either side are a fuller's workshop and a dealer in lamps, neither of whom you will find among the complainants, because I pay the fuller well and the lamp-seller's daughter was married from this house with a dowry I do not discuss. If the committee wants complainants, it will have to import them, like the marble in the emperor's forum. It can be done. Everything can be done. I merely note the cost of transport.”

He looks at her then, directly, with something that is not quite respect and not quite warning. “The proposal comes from a name that does not lose, madam.”

“All names lose,” Antonia says. “The trick is to lose at something that does not end you. Show him the kitchen, Diomedes. Let him see the new stove. Men who have seen a kitchen find it harder to describe a house as a den. A den does not usually have a pastry cook from Alexandria arguing about saffron.”

■

Lentulus hears the report in a room off the Basilica where the light falls in tall, dusty slabs and every conversation sounds as if it were already being transcribed by history. The aedile's man is apologetic in the way of officials who have found nothing and must make nothing sound like diligence. Registrations in order. Tax paid. Lease valid. Women of legal age and status, each accounted for. No unregistered slaves found on the premises. The house is, on paper, a dining establishment of unusual cleanliness.

"On paper," Lentulus repeats.

"On paper, senator, half of Rome is a temple."

It is a good line and the man knows it and regrets it in the same breath. Lentulus lets it pass. He has the colder problem of having aimed a public instrument at a private target and struck, with great precision, her paperwork — which she will now certainly have framed by the sheer force of having survived him.

Postumus, who has attached himself to the meeting in the manner of a relative who considers proximity a form of counsel, says when they are alone, "You knew she'd be clean. She was always clean. Even when —" He stops, with the belated tact of a man who has drunk at too many tables where the past was served as a side dish.

"Even when," Lentulus says pleasantly, "is not a period of history the Senate recognises. What do the banks say?"

Postumus brightens. Money is a country where his accent is native. "Her money is not where you'd think. Some in property through freedmen, some in loans through a Greek at the Basilica — very respectable Greek, the kind other Greeks call Roman when they want to insult him. She lends like a senator and collects like a landlord." He hesitates. "There is a rumour she holds paper on half the young men who dine there. Debts of honour, settled into debts of record. Quietly."

"Paper on whom, exactly?"

“Exactly is expensive. Approximately is free. Approximately: everyone you would not want named in a committee.” Postumus watches him. “Old friend. If this is policy, it is bad policy, because she is cleaner than the policy. If it is not policy, it is worse, because she will know the difference even if the Senate pretends not to.”

Outside, the Forum crowd of the previous day has thinned into litigants and money-changers and the perpetual float of men waiting to be noticed by other men. Lentulus stands a moment under the portico and does an unfamiliar thing: he considers what he is doing as someone else might witness it. A man of ancient family, a former consul, a candidate in all but announcement for the Syrian command that will precede the emperor's eastern war, devoting the first weeks of the year to the registrations of a dining house on the Caelian. There are explanations a hostile world could supply. There is the explanation he supplies himself at hours when supply is low: that the city is rotting at its pleasures, that young men of good family are mortgaging estates to freedwomen's bankers, that someone whose name still means something must be seen to mean it.

The explanations hold together like a speech. They have that in common with speeches: they work best aloud, to others.

■

The embroiderer comes again on the third day, because Antonia, having seen the hanging up in the great dining room, has sent word that the border wants another row of the small red flowers whose name she does not know, and that the house will pay for the thread separately. The girl — no, Antonia corrects herself, the young woman; she dislikes in herself the diminishing word she hears all day from men — arrives with her work-box and her father's permission written in her posture, shoulders squared against a rebuke for being in such a house at all.

“You may work in the courtyard,” Antonia says. “The light is better and Barbatus will frighten away anyone who thinks a woman sewing is

a woman waiting to be spoken to."

"My father says I am not to eat here."

"Your father is protecting your reputation from my kitchen. Very well. You will not eat. You will, however, drink, because I will not have a needlewoman faint among my roses and give the aediles a second report to write."

A smile escapes the young woman and is retrieved, but not fast enough to be unseen. She has a narrow face, dark brows, hands that know their trade so thoroughly the needle seems to be remembering rather than deciding. Her name, entered by Diomedes in the day-book under Payments to Trades, is Vibia Prima. Nineteen. Daughter of a freedman fuller in Transtiberim and a wife who died two winters ago. Betrothed, Eirene has already discovered — Eirene can discover a betrothal through a closed door; it is her one vulgar talent — to a baker's son with a shop near the Trigarium and a mother who inspects Prima's hems as if they were character references.

Antonia watches her work a moment longer than supervision requires. There is a way the girl holds her head when she is counting stitches, chin tucked, mouth slightly open on the number, that plucks at something in Antonia which she files, with the swiftness of long practice, under the general sorrow of watching the young be young in a city that charges for it. She goes back to her accounts.

She does not notice — because she is a woman who notices prices, exits and the weather in a man's voice, and no one notices everything — the small, pale mark on the inside of Prima's left wrist, shaped, if a person were fanciful, like a half-closed eye. The needle goes in. The needle comes out. The red flowers multiply along the border, each one the same, each one, if you look closely, which Prima's future mother-in-law certainly will, very slightly alive with difference.

Chapter Three

Clients in the Morning

. . .

A great house in Rome begins the day by being besieged politely. From first light the atrium fills: clients in clean togas they cannot afford to clean often, freedmen with petitions folded to the size of embarrassment, a poet with an epic in a bucket, two cousins from Arpinum who believe the Cornelii owe their grandfather a magistracy. Servilia moves among the preparations like a quartermaster who has read the campaign plan and found it sentimental. Lentulus receives, remembers names, distinguishes the man who needs a loan from the man who needs the mention of a loan in front of witnesses, and keeps, beneath the surface of the morning, a steady count of what each greeting will cost and in what currency it can be repaid.

It is not cynicism. Or rather, he would say, it is not only cynicism. Patronage is the city's true aqueduct: favour flows downhill, obligation climbs back up, and everyone is wet. His father taught him to receive clients standing, so that no man could say the Cornelii sat while Rome asked. His father also taught him — not in words; in the disposition of estates, in marriages proposed over maps — that a family survives by converting land into loyalty and loyalty back into land before either currency fails.

The man from the Campanian agent is third, and he is the morning's true weather. The harvest loans have been rolled over twice. The interest, compounded through a banker whose name Lentulus prefers not to write in his own hand, now stands against the olive groves above Capua and, behind a veil of legal Latin, against the house on the Palatine itself.

“How long?” Lentulus asks.

“The banker is patient, dominus.”

“Bankers are patient the way rivers are patient. I asked how long.”

“Until the autumn, certainly. Beyond the autumn he will want a payment that signifies intention.”

“A payment always signifies intention. That is its function.”

The agent bows over the blow and withdraws to be given breakfast by a household that feeds its creditors' messengers better than some families feed their sons, because hunger talks.

Servilia, when the atrium has thinned, says, “Cornelia has been asked to sing at the house of the Acilii. She will go, she will sing one song, she will not sing the Greek one. Her voice is an asset and I will not have it spent like loose change.” Cornelia, sixteen, stands in the doorway of her mother's room with a scroll crushed slightly in one hand, being discussed in the third person in the manner of daughters and provinces. She has learnt — Lentulus sees it and is, obscurely, both proud and sorry — not to let her face bid in an auction she is not permitted to enter.

“And the Avidii?” he asks.

“The Avidii have money from shipping and a son with all his teeth. Their name was made by a man who unloaded grain. In two generations it will be an old name, because their grandchildren will pay historians.” Servilia folds a cloth that does not need folding. “We need money that does not smell of the docks, Lentulus, and we need it without being seen to need it. That is the whole of my position. It has been the whole of my position since the Campanian accounts came home in November, and I notice it becomes no larger for being restated.”

Cornelia says, “May I go to my lesson, Mother?”

“You may. Do not let the music master touch your wrist to correct it. He corrects what does not require correction.”

When the girl has gone, Lentulus says, “You think I should take the Avidii.”

“I think you should know the price of refusing them. You have always known the price of everything except refusal. Refusal you treat as free, because your family has been able to afford it for three hundred years.” She looks toward the atrium, where a slave is sweeping the

morning's footprints toward the street door in long, even strokes. “Three hundred years is not a sum of money, husband. It is only a story we tell the money.”

■

Antonia's morning clients are not called clients. They are called the wine merchant wanting a longer credit, the mother of a girl in the Subura who has heard that Antonia pays for midwives without asking whose child it is, the ageing actor who once played kings and now plays, with great dignity, a man asking for the loan of a dining room for his benefit recital. She receives them sitting, because a woman who stands to receive in her own house looks like staff. She receives them quickly, because slowness in others is a tax she declines to pay twice.

Daphne comes last, which is strategy, and not hers alone: Eirene has held her back until Antonia has eaten. Daphne is twenty-two, freed three years, with a voice that makes men believe they have finer feelings than their conduct supports. She is wearing, at an hour when no one is performing anything, a necklace of green stones that Antonia has not seen before.

“Sit down,” Antonia says. “Take it off first. I want to talk to you, not to it.”

Daphne takes it off with the languor she uses on stage when a heroine removes a crown. In her palm the stones look smaller. Most gifts do, Antonia reflects, when they come off the body and into the light of an office.

“He says they are emeralds.”

“He lies professionally or he lies as a hobby?”

“He is a senator's son. It may be both.”

“Marcus Lentulus,” Antonia says. It is not a question, because Diomedes keeps the door-book better than the Senate keeps its minutes.

Daphne, who is not a fool, stops arranging her face. “He hears me sing. He talks about his father the way men talk about weather in a

country they mean to emigrate from. He has given me glass stones and a great deal of true information, and I think he believes the exchange was the other way round."

"What information?"

"That the father means to press the committee. That there is talk of the Syrian appointment and that the father needs to be seen as a man who cleans stables. That the sister is to be sold — his word is married, but he is twenty and drunk on being the only honest man in his family — to shipping money. That the Cornelii owe—" she pauses "—everyone."

Antonia is very still. In the courtyard someone laughs, a real laugh, the pastry cook's, and a dove answers from the roof tiles with its soft, stupid music. "You will give the necklace back," she says.

"Antonia—"

"You will give it back with the message that you admired it too much to risk it among musicians. He will understand that he has been caught lying and forgiven beautifully, and he will be yours for another month and truthful for at least a week. Glass accepted is a price agreed, Daphne. I did not free you — I did not pay your former owner a sum I still resent remembering — so that a Lentulus could buy you again wholesale."

"You say his name," Daphne says quietly, "the way other people say a street they used to live in."

"I say it the way I say the tax office. With respect for its power to inconvenience me." Antonia stands, which ends it. But at the door she stops, because the girl — the young woman, the freedwoman with glass in her palm — is looking at the stones as if they might yet argue their case. "You want things that are real," Antonia says, more gently. "So did I. The city will offer you a great many shining substitutes and call your refusal ingratitude. Refuse anyway. A real stone can be sold in a bad winter. Remember which of the two you are collecting."

■

That night the house fills in its ordinary, extraordinary way: a grain contractor celebrating a contract he cannot yet announce, two equestrians negotiating a partnership over courses designed to slow them down, an elderly advocate who comes for the music and stays, chastely and entirely, for the pleasure of being listened to by women who are paid to find the law interesting and have become, over the years, genuinely formidable on the subject of inheritance. Antonia moves between rooms as she always moves, present everywhere the way a key signature is present in music. She tastes the sauce for the dormice and sends it back. She settles, with four words and a hand on an elbow, a quarrel between cousins over a wager on the races. She notes, without writing, that the grain contractor's partner drinks only water after the fish course, which means he is either ill, devout, or negotiating in earnest — and files it under all three.

At the second hour of the night Diomedes brings her, among the ordinary messages, a folded note with no seal, in a hand she knows before she opens it the way one knows a step on a stair.

It says: *Withdraw the young men and I withdraw the committee. We need not meet to arrange what we both understand.*

There is no signature. Lentulus never learned that an unsigned note is still a signature if the handwriting is the one that taught you, at seventeen, how to shape the letter that begins your name.

Antonia holds it a moment over the lamp — not to burn it. She never burns paper that could be evidence or leverage or, on a night when the accounts are done and the house is loud with other people's appetites, company. She folds it once, precisely, and puts it in the box where she keeps the tax receipts, between the quarters.

“Tell the messenger,” she says to Diomedes, “that the house thanks his master for his interest in its guest list, and that the guest list, like the tax receipts, is filed quarterly.”

Diomedes, who has translated her meaning into survival for eleven years, bows and goes to find the exact tone in which a non-answer can be made to sound like a door closing in a well-built house.

Chapter Four

What the Baths Know

. . .

The baths at the eighth hour are Rome with its clothes off and its guard, paradoxically, up. Steam, oil, the slap of feet on wet mosaic, a ball game in the exercise yard conducted with the seriousness of a border dispute. Lentulus goes twice a week and never on the days his son goes, an arrangement both of them maintain without ever having made it. A man's friendships are audited in the baths. So are his enmities; the water carries everything.

Acilius, who will be consul within the year if the emperor's favour holds, falls into step beside him in the warm room with the ease of a man who has rehearsed spontaneity. “Syria,” Acilius says, naming the whole conversation in advance so that they can both pretend to have wandered into it. “The emperor will want a governor in place before he moves east. A name that reassures the legions and does not frighten the Senate. Yours is spoken.”

“Names are spoken in baths the way steam is made. Abundantly and on purpose.”

“Yours is also spoken at dinner.” Acilius lowers himself into the water with a sigh that is half politics, the sound a man makes to suggest that what follows is reluctant. “There is one — untidiness. It is said your committee work looks personal. In a candidate for Syria, personal is a colour the emperor does not wear.”

“And who says it looks personal?”

“People who dine on the Caelian.” Acilius smiles with his eyes only, a trick of men who expect to be carved one day and are practising for the bust. “Old friend, I have eaten there. Half the men who will vote on your appointment have eaten there. The food is excellent and the discretion has been, until now, architectural. If you shake that house, things will

fall out of it. Some of them will have names you need."

The water is at Lentulus's ribs. Heat works on the old injury in his shoulder, the one from a horse in Moesia that history has since promoted into something more martial in other people's telling. He thinks of his father's voice on the subject of appetites: *A Cornelius may have them. He may not be had by them.* He thinks, unbidden and therefore with irritation, of a courtyard in a house that no longer stands, of a girl laughing with a stylus behind her ear like a flower, utterly unaware that a stylus behind the ear was, in his father's Rome, a flag planted on the wrong hill.

"I am not shaking a house," he says. "I am proposing that houses which profit from the sons of senators be registered, taxed and inspected like any other trade that could burn a neighbourhood down. If that reads as personal, it is because Rome personalises everything except responsibility."

"Then make it read as general," Acilius says mildly. "Inspect ten houses. Inspect twenty. At present you have inspected one, at dawn, by committee. Rome can count, Lentulus. That is its least attractive quality."

■

Marcus hears about the conversation before his father's oil is dry, because the baths have a second plumbing system, made of slaves, and his dice creditors keep him plumbed in. He hears it in the version that will do the rounds by dinner: *Lentulus warned off the Caelian by Acilius. Syria in the balance. The woman has names.* He is twenty years old and the news strikes him not as danger but as proof — proof that the house on the Caelian, where the wine is honest and a freedwoman sings like a person addressing him rather than his pedigree, is the one true place in Rome where power admits what it is.

He goes there that night because going there has acquired, in the alchemy of prohibition, the flavour of a political position. Antonia sees

him come in. She sees the friend he has brought, a young Avidius with shipping money and a laugh too loud for the room he is in, and she performs, in a single glance exchanged with Diomedes, the whole arithmetic of the evening: what the boy's presence costs his father, what it earns the house, what it risks for Daphne, who is — she hears it in the first phrase — singing better than she has sung all month, which is its own kind of risk.

"You should send me away," Marcus says to her in the interval, with the bravado of youth offering its hostess a sword to fall on. "My father would. In your place."

"I am not in his place," Antonia says. "That has been established by committee. Drink your wine slowly, Marcus. It is the only advice I give young men that they can follow without a tutor."

"He wants you closed."

"He wants to be seen wanting me closed. There is a difference, and the difference is where I live." She is aware, even as she says it, of the Avidius boy listening with the deep attention of new money at an old lesson. She pitches the next sentence for him too. "Your father and I disagree about the governance of this city. He believes it is governed from the Senate house. I believe it is governed wherever men tell the truth after the fish course. We are both, in our way, patriots."

Marcus laughs, delighted, disloyal, young. Across the room Daphne returns the necklace — Antonia watches the choreography, the little press of the palm, the sentence about musicians — and watches the boy receive his own lie back as a keepsake, and love the woman who returned it the way men love being forgiven beautifully: entirely, and for about a week, exactly as predicted.

Prima is there that night too, but not as guests are there. She has come after dark because the baker's mother, that inspector of hems, has kept her all day unpicking a sleeve, and the border of red flowers must be finished before the hanging is wanted for a banquet of Alexandrians. She works in the small room off the courtyard where the linen is kept, and through the half-open door she can hear the singing, and under the

singing the talk, and under the talk a quality she does not have a word for, though she will learn several before the year is out: ease. The ease of people who believe the room will hold them.

Barbatus brings her water without being asked, which for Barbatus is a speech. “Your father know you're here after dark?”

“My father knows I am finishing work for a house that pays on the day.” She bites off a thread. “He knows the name of the street. He chooses the rest of his knowledge the way we all do.”

Barbatus, who killed men in the arena for eleven years and has since developed strong views about the management of doorways, considers this. “You've a look of someone,” he says.

“So have you. It's called a face.”

He laughs, a sound that turns a head or two in the courtyard, and goes back to his door. But the remark stays with him, the way a song stays, trivial and exact. He has a look-of-someone feeling about the needlewoman, and Barbatus trusts his instincts in proportion to how little language they require.

■

Eirene is the one who says it. Later, much later, when the guests have gone and the money has been counted and the lamps are being trimmed down to their night setting, she says it in the tone of a woman putting a cup exactly in the middle of a table. “The needlewoman. Prima. Have you looked at her, Antonia? Not at her work. At her.”

“I look at everyone. It is how this house survives.”

“You look at everyone the way a customs officer looks at cargo. Look at her the way you look at a mirror in bad light. Against your will.”

Antonia's hands, which are counting by touch — she can count coin in the dark, a skill from a life she does not narrate — do not stop. That they do not stop is information, and Eirene, who has known her since they were both somebody else's property in a house in the Subura where

the stairs smelled of cabbage and ambition, receives it as such.

“She is a fuller's daughter from Transtiberim,” Antonia says. “She is betrothed to a baker. She sews a straight seam. Rome is full of girls — women — with dark brows, Eirene. It manufactures them. It is one of its industries.”

“Count her years.”

“I have counted everything in this house twice today.” The coins go on moving. “Do not make me count that.”

Eirene says nothing more. She puts the trimmed lamp down between them, where it burns with a small, upright flame, and the two women sit a while in the aftersound of the house — water somewhere, a latch, Barbatus telling the night porter a story with a long, dishonest preamble — while Antonia finishes the count and gets it wrong, and begins again, and gets it right, and writes the right number down in a hand that only shakes on the last figure, where no one who did not already know her would think to look.

Chapter Five

A Short History of Stairs

. . .

She does not tell it. That is the first thing to understand about Antonia and the past: it is not a story she withholds, the way other women withhold a lover's name for the pleasure of the withholding. It is more like a room in a house she owns, whose door she keeps locked not from shame but from housekeeping. What would be the use of opening it daily? The furniture does not change. And yet a house is shaped by its locked rooms. the people outside them learn to walk certain ways.

There was a house, though. Let the record — which is only her, at night, settling accounts the tax office will never audit — admit that much. A house on the Quirinal, old, cold in winter through some principle of its architecture, where her mother, freed too late to enjoy it and dead too soon to describe it, had been a hairdresser; where Antonia, born while her mother was still enslaved and therefore born, as the law so gracefully puts it, into her owner's property, grew up as an accessory to other women's mornings: holding the mirror, fetching the pins, learning, with the speed of a child who understands that knowledge is the one ration that cannot be short-weighted, to read from the letters left open on dressing tables.

The son of the house was seven years older and home between tutors. This is the locked room's main piece of furniture and she has stopped dusting it: Gnaeus at twenty-four, between a military tribunate and a marriage being negotiated like a border, discovering in his father's house a slave girl of seventeen who could read his Greek over his shoulder and correct, once — once was enough; the room still contains the sound of his laugh — his scansion of a line about a woman at a loom, waiting, which the poet calls faithful and the girl, before she could stop herself, called *unpaid*.

What happened after is not romance, whatever the poets who now eat at her tables would make of it for a fee. It was what happens in houses where one person's *no* is a legal nullity and the other person's *yes* is the weather. And it was — this is the part she has never found a filing place for, not in twenty years of excellent systems — also tenderness. He taught her letters properly, then accounts. He talked, in the manner of young men discovering principles, of manumission as if it were a gift he had personally invented. She believed the teaching and discounted the talking, which is to say she was the only adult in the room, and she was seventeen, and pregnant by the spring.

His father also kept accounts. The old Cornelius — another Gnaeus, they are all Gnaeus, it saves carving — settled the matter the way his class settled rain through a roof: by paying someone else to stand under it. The marriage to Servilia was advanced by a year. Antonia was sold, on a morning when Gnaeus was at a muster on the Campus, to a dealer with a household to staff in Baiae; sold, specifically, *with her increase*, as the contract's Latin puts it, a phrase she read upside down on the dealer's tablet while standing very still with her hands folded, already practising, though she did not know it, for a life in which stillness would be her most expensive garment.

What she remembers of Baiae is stairs. Houses for pleasure are built down hillsides and serviced up them. She remembers the weight of water, the weight in her body changing its address month by month, a midwife with hennaed nails, and a morning — the locked room's floor is worn here, this is where her memory paces — when the child had come in the night and gone by the morning, *not strong*, said the midwife, *a girl, not strong*, and there was money in the midwife's sleeve that had not been there the day before, and Antonia, feverish, emptied, seventeen going on a hundred, did the arithmetic she had been taught by the son of the house and arrived, correctly, at the only conclusion that let her stand up and climb stairs again within the fortnight: that her daughter was dead, because the alternative arithmetic — sold on, given away, exposed on a hillside where the pious left unwanted arithmetic for the gods —

did not permit standing up at all.

She stood up. That is the whole of the heroic part, and it took years. A steward in Baiae liked her head for figures more than her face, a rare ordering she blessed nightly; a widow in Naples freed her in a will, whether from affection or to spite a son-in-law Antonia never asked; freedom turned out to be a staircase too, only now she could charge for the climbing. Loans at interest to women the banks would not see. A share in a laundry. A dining room in Rome, then two, then the house on the Caelian with the damp in the courtyard wall and the pastry cook arguing about saffron. Antonia Cassia is a name she assembled the way she assembled everything else: good materials, no one's permission.

She does not tell it. Eirene knows the shape of it, the way a person who shares a house knows where the locked room is without ever being shown. And if a needlewoman from Transtiberim holds her head, when counting, exactly the way — no. The count of coin is finished. The count of years she will do when she must, and she has decided, nightly for some days now, that she must not yet.

■

Lentulus does not tell it either. His locked room is better built; architects cost money, and the Cornelii have always spent on structure. In his version, which he has not rehearsed aloud in twenty years and therefore believes to be unrehearsed, he came home from the muster to a father's study redolent of wax and finality and was told that the girl had been sold south, comfortably, *the matter concluded*, and that his marriage would be celebrated in the autumn, and that a man's youth is a province he governs badly and then, if he is fortunate in his family, is recalled from before the audit.

He asked one question. This is the worn floor in his room. He asked whether there had been a child. His father, who had governed provinces and understood the load-bearing capacity of a pause, said: “There is nothing living with a claim on this house.”

Lentulus was twenty-four. He took the sentence as an answer because he needed it to be one, and he has spent twenty years paying interest on that act of interpretation — in the small hours, in the Senate when a debate touches the exposure of infants or the rights of freedwomen and he finds his own voice arriving before his judgment; in the particular ferocity, which his friends call principle and his wife calls by no name at all, with which he pursues the regulation of houses where other men's sons go to make Gnaeus's arithmetic and call it love.

He married Servilia in the autumn. She knew. He understood that she knew within the first month, from a sentence about Baiae dropped into a conversation about oysters with the precision of a stone into a well, to hear the depth. They have never spoken of it again. It is one of the load-bearing silences of the marriage, along with the Campanian debts and the fact — observed by both, acknowledged by neither — that Servilia would have made the better senator.

His father died consul and honoured. The will, when it was read among the masks, contained the usual bequests and one unusual one: a sealed tablet for Gnaeus's eyes, which Lentulus, being his father's son in the matter of locked rooms, has kept sealed for nine years in the cupboard under his grandfather's mask. He tells himself it concerns the estates. He does not open it for the same reason Antonia does not count Prima's years: some arithmetic, once performed, must be acted on, and he has Syria in prospect, and a daughter to marry, and a committee proceeding against a house on the Caelian whose mistress taught him, though she would laugh to hear it, everything he knows about the difference between what a thing is called and what it is.

You tell yourself the tablet is about olive groves. You have always been good at telling yourself things in the tone of a committee, as if a minuted untruth were sturdier than a spoken one. The masks look down. Wax, smoke, paint. Every one of them a man who locked a room and called the house honest.

Chapter Six

The Avidii at Dinner

. . .

To marry Cornelia well, it is first necessary to feed the people who might buy — the word the family uses is *ally with* — a large number of dinners at which nothing is proposed and everything is assessed. Lentulus dines the Avidii in the third week of the year. Servilia has chosen the menu as a general chooses ground: no dish that requires apology, no wine that suggests either desperation or the newer taste for novelty, and for the centre of the table a boar from the Cornelian woods, because a family that can serve its own boar is still, in the deepest Roman sense, a family that owns the story of its dinner.

Avidius the father is sixty, rich from grain fleets, freeborn son of a man who unloaded them, and possessed of the most dangerous quality in a negotiator: he is genuinely unembarrassed. His son, the young Avidius of the Caelian evenings, sits at the lowest couch and tries not to look at Cornelia with the expression he uses for singers. Cornelia, who has been dressed by her mother into a masterpiece of modesty with a neckline, performs the dinner the way she performs her music lessons, correctly and with an inner life entirely elsewhere, which her father, catching it, recognises as the Lentulus inheritance more truly than the name.

“Your committee does you credit,” Avidius says over the fish, because new money always compliments old money on its morals; it costs nothing and it sounds like a subscription. “The city wants order. Order is good for shipping.”

“Order is good for everything except conversation,” Lentulus says, and the table laughs on cue, and he hates the laugh a little, the purchased sound of it, though he has made the joke precisely to purchase it.

It is Marcus who breaks the evening, as water finds the crack in a jar. He has drunk exactly enough to mistake honesty for courage. “Father's

order begins on the Caelian," he says. "One house at a time. The committee has a short list."

Silence, with cutlery. Servilia looks at her son the way an engineer looks at a bridge. Avidius the father, who built a fortune by hearing what a room costs, hears this room's price change and files it without moving his face at all. Young Avidius studies his hands. Cornelia — Lentulus sees it peripherally, the way one sees weather — stops being elsewhere. She is entirely, dangerously present.

"My son," Lentulus says, "has the advocate's fault of stating a case before he has been briefed. The committee's list is the city's list. All unregistered establishments."

"Of course," Avidius says, warm, rich, unconvinced, already recalculating a dowry against a scandal surcharge in the privacy of a mind that has never once confused a dinner with a pleasure. "All Rome. Naturally."

Later, when the guests have gone, Servilia does not raise her voice. She has raised it perhaps four times in nineteen years of marriage; the household still tells the stories. She says, "Your son dines at that house and then discusses yours at my table. Your daughter has just learnt that her marriage is a transaction at which her brother may heckle. And Avidius has learnt that the Cornelii can be embarrassed at their own board, which he will presently charge us for. This is your committee's work, Lentulus. I hope the Senate applauds it as warmly."

"The boy will be spoken to."

"The boy is twenty. Being spoken to is your family's substitute for every other form of action." She is removing her jewellery, piece by piece, into the hands of a slave who has heard everything in this room for a decade and will die having said none of it for money, because Servilia pays for silence prospectively, in kindness, which compounds better. "End it, or win it. Do not keep it. A kept quarrel is a pet, and this family cannot feed pets."

Marcus, spoken to, goes straight to the Caelian, because at twenty the shortest distance between a rebuke and its repetition is a straight line. The house is quieter tonight: rain, a thin Roman rain that makes the streets shine and keeps the merely curious at home. Daphne is not singing. She is sitting in the small dining room mending a torn strap on her costume — they all mend, Antonia insists on it, a house policy older than Daphne's freedom: no woman here is only ornamental, it rots the soul and the budget — and Prima is beside her, detained by the rain, showing her how to set a stitch so the tear will not remember itself.

Marcus, wet-shouldered, eloquent with grievance, tells the room about the dinner. He tells it well. He has his father's gift for a sentence and none of his father's instinct for an audience. Prima, listening, hears a senator's son describe his sister's marriage as a sale and his father's morals as a siege, and she thinks — with the practical clarity of a girl whose own betrothal contract was read aloud to her once, quickly, by a father who stumbled on the clause about her dowry of tools — that the rich are simply poor people whose transactions have better Latin.

“You shouldn't talk about your sister like that,” she says.

The room looks at her. Daphne's needle stops. Marcus, who is accustomed to being the most interesting thing in any room under senatorial rank, experiences the novel sensation of being corrected by the furniture, and — to his credit, or to Daphne's influence, or to the rain — he does not reach for rank.

“Why not? It's true.”

“Because she isn't here to tell it wrong herself.” Prima ties off the stitch. “My mother used to say a hem tells you how a garment was treated when no one was looking. So does a story.”

“My mother,” Marcus says, “says nothing at all, in several languages.” But he says it without the laugh he arrived with. He looks at Prima then, properly, the way the baths slaves say men look when a lane opens unexpectedly not before them but beside them. “Have I seen you? At the house of — no. At the fuller's. You're the fuller's girl who reads.”

“I am the fuller's daughter who sews,” Prima says. “Reading is what I do instead of sleeping. Like your drinking.”

Antonia, coming in at that moment with dry towels for a guest who is not expected to be in her house at all during a committee investigation, hears her own cadence come out of a stranger's mouth — the dry, level understatement she has spent twenty years believing she invented out of necessity in Baiae, on stairs, under water jars. She stands in the doorway with the towels on her arm and the whole house, the rain, the lamps, performing their little conspiracy of ordinariness around her, and she thinks: *No. Not yet. I have a house to lose first. One catastrophe in its proper order.*

“Marcus Lentulus,” she says, “your cloak is dripping on a mosaic older than your family's debts. Barbatus will lend you a dry one and the use of the back street, and if you love your sister as much as you love talking about her, you will be home before your absence becomes a second course. Prima, the rain is easing. Eirene will walk you to the crossing with a lantern. And Daphne —” she looks at the mended strap, the stitch that will not remember itself “— good. That is how all repairs should look. As if nothing were ever torn. We are none of us required to believe it.”

Chapter Seven

Paper

. . .

Diomedes keeps three sets of books in three different hands, none of them his own. It is not dishonesty; it is calligraphy in the service of survival. There is the book for the tax office, upright and dull. There is the book for the house, in which the pastry cook's saffron and the enlargement of the kitchen stove stand in their true relations. And there is the book — tablets, actually, wax renewed each quarter so that some kinds of history melt as a matter of policy — in which Antonia's money goes out into Rome in the evening clothes of other men's names and comes home in the morning with interest.

“You hold paper,” Diomedes says, on a grey morning when the damp has come through the courtyard wall in the shape, Eirene says, of Spain, “on the agent of an estate in Campania. It came to us through the Greek at the Basilica. It is good paper. Land, olives, a family's good name standing behind it like a guarantor at a wedding.”

Antonia is dressing her hair, which she still does herself on principle, another relic: a hairdresser's daughter does not sit idle in that particular chair for any woman living. “Whose good name?”

Diomedes, who can usually deliver any sentence as if it were a weather report, looks at the tablet as if it might revise itself. “The Cornelii Lentuli.”

The pins go in. One, two. Her hands do not ask her permission. “How much of it?”

“Enough that if we called it in the autumn, the olives would be ours by spring. We will not call it. The Greek advises holding. The family will find money — a marriage, an appointment. Families like that always find money eventually; it is lying around in their past like furniture.”

“And if the family does not find money? If the appointment — let us say a province, let us say the east — goes to another name because this name has become, through its own committee work, untidy?”

“Then the paper becomes land. Or it becomes an embarrassment we can sell to someone who collects embarrassments.” Diomedes closes the tablet. “I am telling you because you taught me to tell you everything with a face on it. Money without a face I manage. This has a face.”

Antonia looks at herself in the bronze mirror: a woman of thirty-eight with her hair going up correctly and a creditor's knowledge arriving, as the best weapons do, by post, unrequested, already paid for. For twenty years she has imagined — on stairs, in bad winters, in the years when the dining rooms were two tables and a debt to a lamp-seller — the instrument of revenge as something she would have to forge: a letter, a witness, a scene in a basilica with her voice carrying like a trumpet. Rome, being Rome, has delivered it instead as an investment. Lentulus is, through agents and Greeks and the sweet anonymity of paper, in debt to Antonia Cassia. His olives ripen toward her autumn. His son drinks in her house. His committee inspects her drains. The city has tied them together with its favourite knot, the one that looks like business and tightens like fate.

“Hold it,” she says. “Say nothing to the Greek. And Diomedes—”

“Madam.”

“Find out what a fuller in Transtiberim named Vibius paid for his freedom, and when, and whether his household, nineteen or twenty years ago, received — a consideration. From Baiae. Discreetly is not the word. Find out as if you were buying thread.”

Diomedes is still for exactly one breath. He has kept her books for eleven years. He knows which questions have faces on them. “Thread,” he says, and writes nothing down, which in his system is the most serious form of record.

■

In the Basilica Julia, where the money-changers have set up their tables in the same relation to the law courts that remoras bear to sharks, Lentulus instructs his own agent in the music of delay. The banker — the same Greek, though Lentulus does not know the Greek's other client, because the Greek's whole fortune rests on no client knowing any other — is to be assured of the Syrian appointment as if it were a fact slightly too delicate for daylight. The Avidian negotiation is to be mentioned as all but concluded. A payment signifying intention will be made at the vintage. The agent, who has carried this family's intentions downhill for a decade, bows under the weight of them and goes to perform confidence in Greek.

Walking home through the Forum of Caesar, Lentulus is overtaken by the emperor's works traffic: stone for the great column, blocks groaning on rollers, each drum already carved inside with its stair. A foreman tells the senator, unasked — the city tells senators things unasked; it is a tax on the broad stripe — that when it rises a man will be able to climb inside the war and come out on top of it. Lentulus stands a moment watching other men's history inch past on rollers. He thinks of his own name, spiral-cut somewhere between offices and olives, readable only from a distance no living Cornelius will ever stand at.

At home, Servilia has a letter from her brother about Cornelia and a face like a prepared speech. “The Avidii have named a figure.”

“And?”

“It is a figure that pays the Greek and re-ropes the Palatine roof and allows your son to be twenty for two more years without consequences. In exchange they ask that the wedding be before the vintage, and that you speak for the father's petition about the harbour dues, and — this is the interesting clause, Lentulus, attend to it — that this family not be *in the mouths of the city* between now and the ceremony. Avidius used those words. He has bought his way out of the docks. He will not buy his way into a farce.”

“So my committee must conclude.”

“Your committee must conclude, your son must be invisible, and you must be a wall. Not a window.” She hands him her brother's letter like a verdict she has already appealed in private. “I do not say take them. I say this is the price of refusing them, itemised. You may now perform the Cornelian tradition of refusing at length and in excellent Latin, and in the autumn the Greek will perform the Greek tradition of owning our olives.”

He reads the letter. The figures are what figures are: an argument that has stopped pretending to be anything else. Somewhere in the house Cornelia is at her lesson; he can hear the lyre being corrected, note by note, by a man forbidden to touch her wrist. The sound comes through the walls the way light comes through shutters, in stripes. He thinks of the sealed tablet under his grandfather's mask, and of the possibility — he has never permitted it a whole thought; it arrives in stripes too — that what his father sealed was not about land at all, and that a man can inherit a debt that does not appear in any Greek's ledger because it is denominated in a currency bankers fear to touch.

“Tell your brother,” he says, “that we are honoured, and that I will give Avidius my answer after the committee reports.”

“When does the committee report?”

“The committee,” Lentulus says, with the exhausted accuracy of a man reading his own inscription, “reports when I tell it to. That has become, I gather, the problem.”

Chapter Eight

The Alexandrians

. . .

The banquet of Alexandrians has been booked since December, and like all Antonia's profitable evenings it rests on a lattice of small, unglamorous decisions: who is placed where the kitchen noise reaches least, which singer does Greek without making the Romans feel examined, what to serve men from Egypt who consider Roman cooking a promising provincial attempt. The great dining room has its new hanging, Prima's red flowers marching the border like a well-drilled cohort, and the lamps have been filled by a boy who has been threatened, kindly and specifically, about the consequences of a smoky wick.

The guests are merchants of the grain fleet and their Roman partners, and among the partners, inevitable as a harbour due, is Avidius the father. He eats in Antonia's house the way he buys cargo space, with an evaluator's love. “Your cook has improved the fish,” he tells her, which from Avidius is a love letter. “Last year it was ambition. This year it is fish.”

“I shall tell him. He will pretend to be insulted and raise his price.”

“You will pay it. Quality is the only bribe that keeps giving evidence in your favour.” He looks around the room; at the Senator's nephew holding a conversation with the singer Philomela about metre, at two tax farmers burying a partnership in the third course and resurrecting it by the fifth. “I am to marry my son into the Cornelii,” he says, in the tone of a man discussing the weather at sea. “If the Lentulus does not drown the match first, wrestling with your paperwork. Tell me, Antonia — you may; everyone else here is paid not to — will he?”

“He will do what his family has always done. He will discover, at the last moment, a principle that coincides with solvency.”

Avidius laughs, the deep harbour laugh. “You know him.”

“I know the type. Rome has a mould.” She moves to go, because a hostess who lingers is a hostess auditioning, but Avidius, who has spent forty years reading the moment cargo shifts, shifts his couch-weight almost imperceptibly into her path.

“Between ourselves,” he says. “I have made my money not frightening. I unloaded grain, my son unloads nothing heavier than a lyre, my grandson will unload provinces. It requires that nothing with my name on it be laughed at in the baths. If your house and his committee are going to make my family's wedding into a mime, I would rather buy a different old name. There are several for sale, though they call the shop something else.”

“Then tell him so.”

“I have. In a letter about figures. Men of his mould only read figures. It is their poetry.” Avidius takes an olive. “You hold paper, I am told, in several directions at once. It is a talent. Paper is the only freedman who never forgets his place, because his place is wherever you file him.”

She looks at him then, really looks, the customs officer at the cargo, and Avidius — who respects competence the way priests respect omens — inclines his head the smallest degree a rich man can manage without spraining anything. Nothing has been said. Everything has been invoiced.

■

It is the senator's nephew who dies. Later there will be versions — the house will accumulate versions the way the Tiber accumulates offerings — but the version Antonia keeps, the housekeeping version, is this: a man of thirty, overweight, over-wined, with a heart his physician had already described to his wife in the words physicians use for a roof in a bad street, laughing at a story in the interval between courses; a choke that was not a choke; Philomela, who has presence of mind the way other singers have jewellery, getting him upright and calling for the

physician who lives two streets away and dines, on Antonia's standing arrangement, with one ear open; the physician arriving fast and working competently and the man's colour deciding, as colour does, to leave anyway, all of it over in less time than the kitchen needs to ruin a sauce.

A death in a house like hers is not a tragedy first. It is a legal shape first, and a rumour immediately after, and a tragedy — for a wife two streets away is receiving the news from Barbatus, who has taken off his door-keeper's face and put on the human one he keeps for such errands — in its proper place, which is everywhere and therefore nowhere the aediles can measure.

Antonia does the things. She has rehearsed the things the way ships rehearse fire. The room is cleared without panic. The other guests are given cloaks and discretion and the back street in ones and twos, with the bill forgotten by policy and remembered by gratitude. The body is laid in the small courtyard room, decently, with a coin and clean linen, and no one, *no one*, is permitted to say the word poison within the walls, because words are seeds and this house will not garden its own ruin. Diomedes writes the evening down while it is still warm: who was present, what was served, the hour, the physician's name, the sequence, in the upright dull hand of the tax book, because truth, to survive in Rome, must learn to look boring on paper.

Avidius is among the last to leave. At the door he says, “You run a tight ship in a storm.”

“It was not a storm. It was a man laughing, with a bad heart, in a city that feeds men like him for thirty years and then blames the room he dies in.”

“All the same.” He puts on his cloak. “The Lentulus committee will not call it that. Mind your paperwork, Antonia. And mind who profited from a death in your house this quarter. Sometimes a thing is an accident with excellent timing, and sometimes—” he shrugs, a harbourman's shrug, philosophical and entirely sincere “—sometimes the timing is the accident's employer.”

She stands in the doorway after he has gone, in the smell of lamp oil and cooling food, and listens to her house performing its grief procedures: low voices, water, linen. Eirene comes to stand beside her without touching her, which is how they touch.

"Second catastrophe," Antonia says. "In its proper order."

"What was the first?"

"I am not counting those yet either."

Chapter Nine

An Inquiry

. . .

A death in a dining house belongs, by the city's old and flexible anatomy, to several jurisdictions at once, which means it belongs to whoever moves first with the best Latin. By the second hour of the morning the dead man's uncle the senator has written to the urban prefect; by the third, Antonia's physician has deposited, at her instruction, a sealed account with a notary she has paid for years precisely against the day someone's heart would table a motion. By noon the baths have decided that the man was poisoned by a rival for a singer's favours, cuckolded by a tax farmer and carried out singing, three deaths, all false, all immortal. Rome does not mind an inquiry. Rome minds having nothing to say while it proceeds.

Lentulus receives the news at his clients' hour, in the mouth of a freedman who brings petitions and relishes disaster the way pastry cooks relish saffron: professionally, and more than he admits. He dismisses the man mid-flourish. He stands in his own atrium among the masks with the information arranging itself in him like troops: his committee, her house, a corpse, the city's tongue. He is aware — he will be able to date the awareness later, to this minute, to the quality of light through the compluvium — of a feeling he cannot at first name because it has arrived wearing the wrong uniform. It is not satisfaction. It has the shape of its opposite, hurrying.

Servilia, who has also heard — Servilia hears everything at the speed other people take to decide whether to repeat it — says from the doorway, “Do not go there.”

“I have no intention of going there.”

“You have every intention of being the man Rome watches not going there. It amounts.” She comes into the room. “If you press this now, you

will look like a creditor applauding a fire. If you defend her, you will look like—" She stops, not for want of the word.

"Like a man who inspects a house at dawn and eulogises it by noon."

"Like its patron," Servilia says, with surgical calm. "The Avidii will read it. The emperor's secretaries will read it. Your daughter, Lentulus, will read it, in the faces at dinner for the rest of her unmarried life."

"So I am to let the prefect's men establish whether a man died of his heart or of her fish, and my committee is to master the antiquarian skill of silence."

"You are to let the truth be established by men who do not love or hate in that street. It is a short list. The physician is on it, I understand, because *she* had the foresight to employ him before she needed him. There is a lesson in that for families who arrange their credit after the vintage."

She goes. The masks remain. Lentulus looks up at his grandfather — Gnaeus, naturally, the dented-mirror Gnaeus, under whose cupboard a sealed tablet has been ripening for nine years — and has the clearest thought of his morning, the kind a man buries standing up: *If I open it, it is because a man has died at her table. Everything in this family requires a death to become sayable.*

He does not open it. He sends, instead, an unsigned note by a slave who is not his usual messenger, which is the most signature-like act available to a Cornelius: *Keep the physician's account sealed until the prefect asks. Answer in the order of the evening, not the order of the questions.*

It is good advice. It is also, and he knows it before the slave has left the street, the first unpaid thing he has done for Antonia Cassia in twenty-one years, and it sits in him for the rest of the day like a coin swallowed in childhood: unnoticed by the world, impossible to forget the swallowing of.

■

The prefect's men are correct, which Antonia prefers; malice she can price, correctness she can plan around. They view the dining room. They view the kitchen, where the pastry cook, misunderstanding the visit in a way she chooses to believe is genuine, offers them almond cakes of a quality that will enter the record nowhere and influence it everywhere. They take the physician's account. They take Philomela's statement, and Philomela — who has sung for these men's superiors and remembers the programme — gives it in the order of the evening, as a certain unsigned advice has suggested, though Antonia would saw her own lyre in half before admitting that the order was not her own idea an hour before the note arrived.

"You keep a physician on retainer," the senior man says.

"I keep a house full of rich men eating dormice in a heat they complain of and pay extra to sit in. A physician on retainer is not foresight. It is tableware."

"And the dead man owed you money."

"Diomedes." The tablet comes, the upright hand, the small sum, a dinner in December and a loan against a racehorse, stamped, witnessed, uninteresting as prayer. "He owed me less than his uncle spends on mourning. If I poisoned debtors of this size, officer, Rome would need a second Tiber."

The man almost smiles, files the smile under conduct unbecoming, and closes the tablet. At the door, with the correctness that has carried them both through the day like a shared umbrella, he says, "The prefect will find a death by misadventure, madam, if misadventure is what the account supports. The prefect is not influenced by committees."

"Tell the prefect the house appreciates inhabiting the same city as his principles."

When they have gone, Eirene says, "The note helped."

"The physician helped. The cakes helped. Notes are just handwriting that has been for a walk." Antonia puts the note in the box with the tax receipts, beside its predecessor, between the quarters: a small, growing archive of a language neither of them writes in anymore and both of

them still read fluently. “Barbatus said the widow asked for me.”

“She asked whether he suffered and whether he was — alone with anyone, at the end. Barbatus said he died laughing at a story about a tax farmer, in a room full of witnesses, with a singer holding his shoulders. She said, 'He would have liked the witnesses.' Then she cried, he said, like a person opening shutters.”

“Send her the December bill,” Antonia says. “Marked settled. And flowers that cost less than the bill, so it doesn't look like arithmetic.”

Eirene goes to arrange the flowers that are not arithmetic. Antonia sits a moment in the emptied dining room under the hanging with the red border, listening to her house's heart resume its ordinary rhythm, and allows herself — the room is empty, the accounts are straight, a man is dead who died laughing and there are worse inscriptions — one unfiled thought, arrived in a familiar hand: *In the order of the evening, not the order of the questions.* It is how you tell any story if the telling is to save you. It is how she has never yet told hers.

Chapter Ten

Transtiberim

. . .

Diomedes goes to Transtiberim to buy thread. He buys, in the course of a slow and scented morning among the fullers' vats — urine and earth and the clean, assertive smell of other people's garments being forgiven — a great deal of thread. He buys red, which the house does not need, and undyed linen thread, which it does, and he buys, with the unhurried negligence of a man spending someone else's money on someone else's errand, the following: that Vibius the fuller was freed twenty-two years ago by a master in the tanning trade; that his wife, dead two winters, was a Baiae woman, a laundress, who came to Rome in the household of a dealer; that the couple, childless through the first years of their freedom, took in a child in the winter of the year the old emperor died — a girl, days old, brought by a midwife whose nails, an old woman at the vat remembers unprompted and then wishes she hadn't, were hennaed; that money came with the child, not much, regularly, for some years, then stopped, as money does when the hand that sends it dies or decides the account is closed; that the girl was raised as born to them — “and whose business is it, Greek?” says the old woman, suddenly, with the fuller's wife's whole defensive city in her voice — “she was fed, she was taught, she's betrothed to a baker with a mother like a customs office, she is *theirs* in every way the gods inspect—” and Diomedes, who has what he came for and more than he wants, buys thread from the old woman at her price, which is also a way of saying: this conversation is a transaction; I was never an inquiry.

He walks home across the island bridge slowly, a freedman in early middle age carrying thread and an undetonated century. He has served Antonia eleven years. He knows her books' three handwritings, her policy on glass jewellery, the exact depth of the silence she keeps about

Baiae; he has never, in eleven years, seen her face do what he is now obliged to walk toward and cause. He composes, as all good secretaries compose, the order of the evening. He decides against the order of the questions. She taught him that herself, years ago, over a disputed invoice: *Tell me what happened, Diomedes. I will supply the cross-examination internally, at my usual rates.*

She listens with a stylus in her hand. She does not write. At the hennaed nails the stylus stops its small, unconscious turning, and at the money stopping it resumes, and these are the only two entries her body makes in the record.

"The year," she says.

"The winter the old emperor died."

"Nineteen years." She counts it aloud at last, in the counting voice, the coins-in-the-dark voice. "Nineteen. The midwife said — not strong. A girl, not strong." The stylus turns. "Who sent the money?"

"The vats do not know. It came through the dealer's people at first. Then through a steward. A Quirinal household steward, the old woman thinks, before she decided she thought nothing."

"A steward." Antonia looks toward the courtyard, where the damp spot has dried in the week's sun to the faintest map of Spain. "My mother's master's steward was called Philodorus. He had a way of settling things at a distance and charging the house for the mileage. He died — Eirene heard it from a laundress — nine years ago. The same winter as old Gnaeus Cornelius." She sets the stylus down in exact alignment with the edge of the tablet, an act of government over the only province presently obeying her. "So the money stopped when the men who were paying to forget had both finished dying."

Diomedes says nothing. It is the most expensive service he renders her, and he renders it now at the full rate.

"I will not have her told by a vat," Antonia says at last. "Not by a Greek buying thread, not by a committee, not by the baths. If there is a telling, it will be in this order: I will be certain; she will be told by someone she already trusts with a needle; and no one — Diomedes,

write this in whichever book governs the end of the world — no one will use her, meanwhile, as an instrument against any living Cornelius. She is not paper. I have paper for that."

"Thread," Diomedes says, and bows, and goes to put eleven years of discretion around a morning's purchases like linen around glass.

■

Prima knows nothing of any of this, which is the last night of not-knowing she will ever sleep in whole, though she has no way to mark it. Her day is fully occupied by the ordinary treacheries: the baker's mother, who has discovered that Prima reads and is consulting her own mother-in-law scars about whether reading in a wife is a dowry or a defect; her father Vibius, whose cough has taken up residence for the winter and is redecorating; the hanging's second border, complete now, paid on the day — with a sum for thread, itemised, which made her father look at her over his soup with the expression of a man who has always known his daughter was worth more than the world agreed and is experiencing vindication as a kind of grief.

"Eat at the house?" he asks.

"Never. As instructed." She pushes his cup toward him; the cough medicine is mostly honey and authority. "The mistress asked after my mother's town. Baiae. I said she talked about stairs. The mistress went quiet the way rich women go quiet at a price."

Vibius looks into his cup for a long time. He is a man who has carried other people's garments through urine and fuller's earth and out the other side clean, and he believes, in his bones, that most things can be got washable if you do not rush the soak. "Your mother," he says, "talked about stairs because in Baiae she worked for a house with ninety of them and a mistress who timed her. She said a person should count stairs so the stairs don't count them." He coughs. "She was the countingest woman I ever knew, your mother. Counting and keeping. Keeping especially."

“Keeping what?”

“Us,” Vibius says, and drinks, and is discovered by his daughter, watching him, to be looking at her with the full apparatus of his love arranged on his face like tools on a bench, which frightens her more than any hem-inspection, because her father is a man who keeps his feelings the way he keeps his accounts: accurately, and at the back.

That night she dreams — she will remember this later, and disbelieve the remembering, and be right both times — of a courtyard with roses and a woman counting coins in the dark, getting it wrong, beginning again. She wakes before the count comes right. The winter light is at the shutter. Her father's cough is counting itself in the next room. She gets up to heat the honey, an ordinary daughter in Transtiberim, last morning of the world as filed, and puts a pot on a small fire with the competence of women in her family going back, though she could not name them, through laundries and dressing rooms, through ninety stairs in Baiae and a mirror held steady at seventeen, all the way down the long female ledger of Romans who kept other people's houses standing and called it, because the language offered nothing better, nothing at all.

Chapter Eleven

The Sealed Tablet

. . .

He opens it on a night of rain because the rain keeps the clients away and leaves the atrium to the masks, and because a man does everything eventually for a reason he would strike from the record. He tells the household he is reviewing the estate papers. He is, in the largest sense his family permits the word: the estate is the past; the papers are its rent book.

The cupboard under his grandfather's mask sticks, as it always sticks in winter. The tablet is where he left it nine years ago, in the scroll-case whose leather has gone the colour of everything in this house that is not wax or wool. His father's seal: the cornel-wood sprig, the old joke of the Cornelii, a family that turned a tree into three centuries of magistracies. He breaks it with his thumb the way you break the skin on cooling milk, hating the delicacy, wanting the violence minuted somewhere.

His father's hand had been a public instrument even in private: large, exact, unhurried by death, which was already in the room when he wrote this — Lentulus can see it at the ends of lines, where the letters gather themselves like men deciding not to run.

Gnaeus to Gnaeus. You will open this late. We are a family that opens things late and calls it dignity. Attend.

The girl from Baiae did not die there. The child — a daughter — lived. I paid the midwife to say otherwise and the steward to place her where the Cornelii would never have to spell her name. A freed couple across the river, fullers, decent people in the way that matters, which is to say they were paid and then, to their credit, continued after the paying stopped being their reason. I had the payments put through Philodorus so that you could truthfully say you knew nothing. You asked me once if there was a child. I said there was nothing living with a claim

on this house. It was the truest sentence available that preserved the house, and I offer you now the observation, too late to be useful to me, that a lifetime of such sentences will preserve a house the way brine preserves meat.

The rain. The compluvium dripping into its basin in the old rhythm, the one that measured his childhood lessons. He reads on, because stopping has never yet been a policy of his family's that survived contact with a document.

I do not write this to be forgiven; your forgiveness would be worth what mine was, a generation too late and addressed to the wrong person. The person wronged is not you. The girl was sold on your muster morning with her increase, as the contract said. I wrote those words too. If you have lived as I surmise you have lived — quietly with it, like a stone in the shoe of a marching man — then you may draw what comfort there is in knowing the girl Antonia lives and prospers in Rome under a name she credits to herself, which is more than I can say for the name I left you. The daughter, if she lives, is called by whatever name decency gave her. I never asked it. There are questions a man of my sort does not ask in case the answer turns out to have a face.

Do nothing dramatic. Drama is a tax the rich impose on the poor to pay for their remorse. If the matter ever stands where this family can settle it at a price that is not the girl's life a second time, settle it. A Cornelius pays his debts. We merely prefer, historically, to choose the currency. Choose better.

Lentulus sits with the tablet open until the lamp needs trimming and no slave comes, because Servilia has instructed the household, with the tactical sense that has kept this marriage upright for nineteen years, that the master reviewing estate papers is not to be improved upon by attendance.

A daughter. Called by whatever name decency gave her. He does the arithmetic that Antonia, across the city, in a house with damp in one wall, has done in exactly the same hour of the same winter: nineteen. A person of nineteen, across the river, in a fuller's household, walking

about Rome in a body half-made of the Quirinal and half of a mirror-girl's, unknown to herself as either, while her father's committee inspects her mother's drains and her half-brother drinks Falernian downstairs from the accounts room where her existence has just been itemised as thread.

He has, until tonight, been able to tell himself that his quarrel with Antonia Cassia is about Rome. It is a story with columns: public morals, young men's debts, Syria. The tablet does not contradict the columns. It simply shows him the ground they stand on, and the ground is a muster morning and a contract phrase and a question asked once by a young man who accepted a statesman's sentence as an answer because the alternative would have cost him his inheritance of himself.

He closes the tablet. He does not reseal it; a Cornelius does not pretend with wax. He puts it back in the scroll-case, under the mask, in the sticking cupboard, and stands a while in the company of the ancestors, who look down with their smoke-dark patience, every one of them a man who chose his currency.

“Choose better,” he says aloud, to no one, and the atrium, being Roman, keeps the remark in the family.

■

Servilia is awake when he comes to bed. She lies in the posture of sleep that she maintains, like the household order, for the benefit of anyone conducting inspections, and says, without opening her eyes, “The estate papers.”

“Yes.”

“Olives?”

“Not olives.” It is the most intimate sentence they have exchanged in some years. The rain goes on sending its small messengers down through the compluvium of the old house into the basin that has received them for three centuries, and somewhere below, a slave who has not been told to stay away from the whole house, only from one room of it,

is damping the kitchen fire for the night, banking it — keeping it, the way the poor keep everything: alive under ash, against the morning, at a price that appears in no one's ledger because it has always been paid.

Servilia says, “Then we will need to be more careful than your father was.”

He looks at her. She has still not opened her eyes. “How long have you—”

“Since the oysters,” she says. “Nineteen years. Sleep, Lentulus. Tomorrow you have a committee. Committees are how this family thinks. God knows it isn't how it acts.”

Chapter Twelve

Negotiations

. . .

They meet at last because Rome, which has been conducting their correspondence through clerks and committees and unsigned walks across the city, finally requires a room. The room is neutral the way a knife is neutral between hands: the back office of the Greek banker at the Basilica, smelling of cedar and other people's solvency, with two chairs and a brazier and a slave who withdraws after the watered wine with the deafness that is his employer's true product.

Antonia arrives first, because in another's office the first arrival owns the silence. Lentulus arrives with rain still in the weave of his cloak, and stands — she remembers this, her body remembers it before she can file it — taking the room the way he used to take a page of Greek, top to bottom, before allowing himself the beginning.

“You sent for me,” he says.

“The Greek sent for us. He has a talent for rooms.” She does not stand. A woman who owns the silence does not surrender the chair. “Your committee has cost me three bookings and gained me a prefect's compliment on my paperwork. I call that, overall, an expensive compliment. I have come to close the account.”

“I did not arrange the man's death to close anything.”

“I know.” She looks at him. “That is how I know it was his heart. If you had arranged it, Lentulus, it would have worked.”

It is the first joke either of them has made to the other in twenty-one years, and it lands between them like a cup set down too hard on glass. Something in his face — she watches it the way she watches a guest's face at the fish course, for the truth under the arrangement, chooses not to pursue it. Business. They are good at business. It is the language Rome taught them both, in different schools with the same fees.

“The committee reports in ten days,” he says. “It will recommend a general registry and quarterly inspection. General, Antonia. Twenty houses. Yours first on the list only by alphabet, which in Latin is mercifully early for nobody.”

“Acilius has been bathing you.”

“Acilius has been right. It happens, even to consuls.” He sits. The chairs are Greek, too low for the dignity of a senator, and he conquers this by ignoring it, a technique his family has applied to provinces. “In return, I ask the house to be — discreet — about young men of senatorial family until the vintage. My daughter's marriage is in negotiation. You know this. Your singer could probably recite the dowry figures.”

“Daphne sings, Lentulus. It is your son who recites.”

A beat. The brazier ticks. Somewhere beyond the cedar door the Greek's fortune goes on being made out of exactly this: two Romans reaching the part they came for by the road they can both describe as the long way round.

“I have a further matter,” Antonia says, in the voice she uses for menus and mercy, “of paper. The Greek will confirm the position if you require it in his hand rather than mine. Loans against Campanian land, rolled twice, now lodged — having passed through the hands of persons who prefer not to hold a senator's vintage in their own cellar — with an investor who files quarterly.” She watches the understanding arrive. It arrives the way age has arrived at his temples: visibly, if you know the face. “I am not calling it in. I am telling you it exists because a weapon a man does not know about is only an asset, and I did not come here to be merely rich at you.”

“How much of it?”

“Enough.” She folds her hands. “I learned that word from men who lend. I find it improves with use.”

“You want the committee buried.”

“I want what you have already offered because Acilius explained the steam to you. A general registry, paid quarterly, like the tax, like the

licence, like everything else in my life that Rome condemns and invoices." She stands, and the room rearranges itself around the single fact of her standing, as rooms have done for her since Baiae. "I have paid this city for twenty years to be let alone in a house I built out of stairs. I will go on paying. It is my civic religion. But I will not be taxed in shame as well as coin because a Cornelius needs Syria to look like cleanliness. We are finished. Unless—"

"Unless," he says.

She has rehearsed this too, the way she rehearses fire procedures and banquet seating: knowing the exact door she must not open under smoke. She looks at him — forty-five, grey-templed, shoulder that aches in warm water, hands that once set a stylus behind an ear as if it were a — no: that is the smoke. Follow the drill. "Unless there is any matter between our houses that your committee has not minuted. In which case the Greek has other rooms, and better wine than this, and we are both too old for the back street."

He is very still. The brazier ticks again, an insect noise, an accounting. "There is a sealed matter," Lentulus says, "that I have recently unsealed."

"Then we will need the other room," Antonia says. And is surprised — she logs it with Diomedes precision, beneath the ribs, where the house's third set of books has always been kept — that her voice does not shake on any figure at all.

■

The Greek's other room has a window, which is how she knows it is for the expensive truths. The Forum below goes about its immortal afternoon: litigants, changers, the column-drums inching on their rollers toward a war already won and not yet tall enough to read. Lentulus stands at the window because the sentence he is carrying has no chair designed for it in any room he owns.

“My father left a tablet,” he says. “I opened it last night. Nine years late. We are a family that opens things late and calls it dignity — those are his words; I am reduced to quoting him, which he would count as the estate settling itself.”

Antonia waits. Waiting is a skill she has, like counting in darkness. She can do it with her whole body arranged to look as if she were doing something else.

“The child lived.”

The room does not change. That is the thing she will remember: the drums on their rollers, the ticking brazier, a money-changer's laugh arriving whole through cedar and glass. The world declining to fall down over the oldest news in it.

“I know,” she says.

She watches it cross him — that she knows, that she arrived at the most expensive truth in Rome ahead of its legal owner, through thread — and what crosses him, under the statesmanship, is a young man of twenty-four being corrected on his scansion by a girl with a stylus behind her ear. *Unpaid*, she had said of the faithful woman at the loom. He had laughed. It had been the laugh that did everything, in the locked room, on the stairs.

“Across the river,” he says. “A fuller's household.”

“Vibia Prima. Nineteen. She sews for my house. She is betrothed to a baker and corrects your son's manners. She counts stitches with her mouth open.” Antonia's hands find each other and are correctly folded before she has decided anything. “She does not know. She will be told by me, when I judge it, in the order of the evening — you may invoice me for the phrase; it was good advice — and not as a weapon in a committee war or a dowry negotiation or a governor's application. She is not paper, Lentulus. She is the one thing in Rome I did not build, and I will not have the Cornelii spending her.”

“My father spent her. In advance, at a discount.” He turns from the window. “I am not here to reclaim her, Antonia. A nineteen-year-old with a trade and a betrothal is not property to be refiled because two

people have finally audited their twenties. I am here to tell you that I know, a day after knowing, and that my wife—" his mouth makes the small, wry shape that in the Senate precedes a concession "—has known since the oysters, apparently, and we will settle money on the household in a form that cannot be traced to the Palatine. Not charity. A debt. My father was precise about the currency, at the end."

"The fuller is dying," Antonia says. "Slowly, of the cough they all get, drinking their trade. Settle it as a widow's portion for a wife already dead and he will refuse it. Settle it as Prima's dowry, enlarged — tools, and a share in the bakehouse, paid through the fullers' guild as a bequest from a Baiae mistress her mother served — and the baker's mother will inspect it like a hem and find it respectable. I have thought about this, Lentulus. I have had, by my count, rather longer with the information than you."

"By how long?"

"Four days." She lets the smallest warmth into it, the way a lamp is let into a room. "I count faster. It is my civic religion."

Below, the drums have stopped for the day; a foreman's shout, the long creak of history parking itself. The two of them stand in a banker's back room between a dead father's Latin and a living daughter's needle, each in possession of the other's ruin in its most portable form — his olives in her book, his name in her locked room, her past in his cupboard — and what they make there, without touching, without the back street or the brazier or any of the instruments their younger selves mistook for fate, is the first entry in a ledger neither of them will ever show the tax office: an agreement to be, for once, jointly and severally, *careful* at somebody else's expense no longer.

Chapter Thirteen

Cornelia's Voice

. . .

Cornelia sings at the house of the Acilii with her mother's instructions arranged inside her like furniture in a room she is permitted to use but not to own: one song, not the Greek; bow to the empress's freedwoman first, because power sits in odd chairs; if the Avidii are there, they are to be greeted as old friends of the family, which by the vintage, the gods and the Greek banker's other rooms willing, they will be able to pretend to have been for years.

She sings the Roman song, a setting of a poem about a woman keeping a house through a war — all the songs for girls are about women keeping houses through wars the men are having elsewhere, and Cornelia, who is sixteen and has been educated well above the safety limit, has begun to notice that the keeping is always the woman's glory and never her choice. She sings it beautifully. She has her Lentulus grandfather's ear and her mother's discipline, a combination that produces, in a drawing room, something perilously like feeling.

Young Avidius is there. He listens with his whole large, shipping-money attention and afterwards, in the supervised eddies of the room, says to her the thing that renews her mother's faith in the match and Cornelia's in humanity, which are not always the same faith: “You should sing the Greek one for people who'd know. My father says a thing wasted is a thing stolen twice.”

“Your father,” Cornelia says, “sounds like a warehouse.”

“He does. It's why there's money.” Avidius grins, unpatrician, unrepentant, entirely without the sullenness Marcus is currently touring Rome with as a philosophy. “I'm not clever like your brother. I'm not going to be a senator who quotes at you. Ships, accounts, a house that won't leak into the dining room — I can do those. If this marriage

happens, nobody'll forbid your wrist to be touched by a music master. They'll just pay him better than your father does, so he respects the merchandise." He winces. "That came out wrong."

"It came out honestly," Cornelia says, surprising them both, "which in my house is what coming out wrong is called."

Servilia, watching from across the room with a mother's optics — able to read a conversation by its shoulders at forty paces — revises, by perhaps half a degree, her private estimate of the Avidii. Money from grain. A boy who can wince. There have been worse foundations under the Cornelii; she can name two without leaving her own marriage.

■

At home Cornelia does a thing she has never done: she asks her father a question in the atrium, at clients' hour, in public — where public means slaves and ancestors, the two audiences a Roman girl is raised to ignore and therefore the only two she entirely trusts.

"Father. If the committee is about houses where men tell the truth after dinner, why does no woman sit on it? We are, I think, the dinners' main consequence."

Lentulus, who has faced down embassies, experiences the specific vertigo of a man whose child has used his own forms against him correctly. "Committees," he says, "are composed of senators."

"Yes. I sat through the tutor too." She is holding her music, not crushing it this time; her hands have learned something this month. "Marcus says the woman on the Caelian keeps Rome's real minutes. He says it to be troublesome, but he isn't clever enough to invent it, which in Marcus amounts to evidence."

"You will not repeat your brother's bath-house evidence at the Acilii."

"I will not repeat anything at the Acilii. I will sing one song, not the Greek, and be a wall." She looks up at the masks, all those smoke-dark uncles of wax. "Did any of them ever ask their daughters a question,

Father? Or is that the Greek song too — the one we keep for people who'd know?"

He should rebuke her. The rebuke is written; his family has been issuing it in fair copy for three hundred years. What he hears himself say, in the atrium, at clients' hour, in front of slaves and ancestors, is: "What would you ask the committee, if you sat on it?"

Cornelia's face does the thing faces do in this family at moments of unminuted honesty: nothing, thoroughly. Only her voice admits the earthquake. "I would ask it why a house where women are paid is a scandal for inspection, and a house where a daughter is dowered to pay a banker is a temple of the ancestors. I would ask it to define *registered*."

"It would not answer."

"No," Cornelia says. "I sit through dinners. I know the sound of the Senate not answering. It is my dowry, in a way. We all bring something." She bows, correctly, and goes to her lesson, and the lyre begins, and is corrected, and begins again — and Lentulus stands among the masks with his daughter's question filed in no book his Greek keeps, and thinks of another girl, at seventeen, with a stylus behind her ear, correcting the scansion on a line about a woman at a loom, and how the Cornelii have been trying to strike that one useful word — *unpaid* — from the record ever since, at compound interest.

Chapter Fourteen

The Committee Reports

. . .

The Senate in the morning is a theatre that has agreed to call itself a constitution. Sun through high windows, the benches filling in order of a precedence everyone affects not to calculate, the emperor's letter read by a secretary with the flat delivery of a man who knows the words will outlive everyone in the room except the building. Lentulus sits where a former consul sits, in the sightlines of power, and listens to a debate about harbour dues with the portion of his mind the Avidii have under option, and with the rest composes, for the last time, the speech he is no longer going to give.

He had drafted it the way his family drafts everything: thoroughly, in periods that could support an aqueduct. *That the city which taxes a trade owes that trade its regulations; that young men of family are mortgaging their grandfathers to freedmen's bankers; that what the aediles cannot find, the Senate has declined to see.* It is a good speech. It would have been quoted in baths. It names no house and aims at one, which is rhetoric's oldest laundry service.

What he gives, when called, is the report. It is four minutes long. A general registry, quarterly fees, inspections at stated hours by appointment of the aediles, twenty-three categories of establishment, penalties for unregistered minors and unfree persons held without manumission papers — a clause he inserted at dawn in his own hand, with Felix the barber waiting, in language tighter than anything the committee's draftsmen produced: *no house to profit by a person whose* no *has no legal existence*. He hears Acilius shift on the bench at the clause, hears the room decide it is a fine sentiment and will be no trouble, hears, under the shuffle of assent, the small, specific silence of men recalculating which of their private arrangements the clause has

just described in public Latin.

Postumus, afterwards, in the portico: “That was either statesmanship or surrender. Your family does both in the same accent. Which is the Senate to put in the minutes?”

“The registry will pass.”

“The registry would have passed in December, before you sent a man to measure one woman's doorways at dawn. Now it passes *over* you, old friend. Syria—” Postumus, who loves him, and has that licence, does the un-Roman thing: he lowers his voice for a truth instead of raising it for a crowd. “Acilius tells me the secretaries have begun to say *Hadrian's people for the east*. Athens has been writing letters. Your name is — spoken, Lentulus. In baths. As steam.”

Lentulus watches the Forum performing its noon: the changers, the litigants, the column stone baking in its yard. “I piloted a morals registry through the Senate and put the freedom of the women in it in words they cannot unwrite without reading them aloud. If Syria is the price, Syria was always going to be paid by someone in some currency. My father—” He stops, surprised by the route. “My father would call that a provincial sentiment.”

“Your father,” Postumus says, with feeling, “has been dead nine years and still schedules the household. Come to dinner. My wife has a singer who does Greek, and she sings it for people who know, which tonight, I fear, means us.”

■

The news reaches the Caelian, as all news does, in three strengths: the door-book version by noon, the baths version by dinner, and Diomedes's version, which is the facts with their shoes on, by the time the evening guests are at the fish. Antonia hears them all. Her house is to be registered quarterly, like the tax, like the licence, like the weather. The clause — Diomedes reads it from the posted text with the neutrality he uses for death notices — about persons whose refusal must have legal

existence, she hears standing still in her own kitchen with a tasting spoon struck dumb in her hand.

The pastry cook, who has strong views on saffron and none that he voices on politics, says, “Mistress?”

“More salt than that, in the sauce for the Alexandrians. They will be back now. Men come back when a house has survived the Senate; it is like a recommendation from a temple.” She gives him the spoon. “Diomedes. Read the clause again.”

He reads it again. Latin, exact, unlovely — the most beautiful letter she has ever not received.

“File it,” she says, “with the tax receipts.”

“Which quarter?”

“Between the quarters. With the rest of his correspondence.”

Chapter Fifteen

Saturnalia Postponed

. . .

Winter lays its flat hand on the city: smoke, short light, the poor burning what the rich have renovated out of. Vibius the fuller declines in the manner of his trade, which is to say by water. The cough brings up the vats' whole history; the guild sends a physician who speaks kindly to Prima and uselessly to the disease; the baker's mother sends soup with inspections in it and finds, to her own surprise, that she is staying to administer both. She is a hard woman, but hardness in Transtiberim is just tenderness that has been charged by the hour for forty years, and Prima, watching her future mother-in-law wipe her father's chin with a cloth she herself has hemmed, revises a ledger she did not know she was keeping.

Antonia hears of the decline from Eirene, who hears of it from Barbatus, who has started walking Prima to the crossing on his own time and bringing back, with the emptied lantern, the news of the street the way other men bring back winnings. Antonia does the things that do not constitute interference in the filings of her conscience: the guild pension enquiries discover a forgotten entitlement; honey of a quality that needs no discussion arrives from a supplier; the physician's second visit is paid before the first has been billed. She stops there. She has built a life out of knowing where a kindness becomes a claim, and she will not begin her motherhood — the word arrives and is set down carefully, like a full glass carried across her own courtyard — as a purchase.

She goes herself, once. Not as the mistress of the Caelian consulting a tradeswoman; veiled, in a cloak Eirene calls her widow-inventing cloak, with Barbatus at a distance that suggests he is escorting someone else entirely. The fuller's house is two rooms and a lean-to over the vats' yard, and it is ordered with the ferocious neatness of people who know

disorder is the first luxury they will be blamed for. Vibius is propped against the wall-bed, grey as undyed wool, and he looks at Antonia for a long moment with eyes that the trade has made professionally sceptical about the true colour of anything.

“The thread lady,” he says.

“The house on the Caelian,” Prima says, flustered, “has come about the hangings for spring, Father. I told her you were to rest.”

“I am resting. It's my busy season.” Vibius's breath goes in like something being wrung. “Sit, mistress, if a stool is not beneath you. Prima, put water on. The mistress drinks—” he looks at Antonia again “—watered wine and not much of it. Working women.” A pause, which the cough fills in its own handwriting. “My wife worked in Baiae.”

“Prima told me. Stairs.”

“Ninety. She counted everything so it wouldn't count her.” The old man is holding the edge of his blanket the way men hold a rail in weather. “She kept what she was given to keep, my wife. Garments. Money. People.” His eyes do not leave Antonia's face. “We were decent people in the way that matters, I hope. We continued after the paying stopped being the reason. Twelve years after. A long soak, mistress. Most things come clean if you don't rush it.”

Prima is at the hearth with her back turned, very busy with water that is already hot. Antonia understands that she is being given, by a dying fuller in a two-room house across the river, the exact respect of not being named. She repays it in kind: “The guild speaks well of this house. The spring hangings will want a firm hand. Your daughter's dowry, I am told, is to include her tools. My house will commission her trousseau work at her own prices. It is how we file respect, across the river. Quarterly.”

Vibius closes his eyes. A smile moves under the greyness like a fish in the Tiber, briefly visible, unquestionably there. “Then we're all filing the same thing, mistress. In different books.”

On the walk back, Barbatus maintains his fiction of escorting nobody until they are at the bridge, where he says, to the river, in the voice men

use for the fights they are remembering instead of the ones they won: “In the arena we had a word for a man who holds the rail and jokes. We called him *not beaten yet*. The fuller's not beaten.”

“No,” Antonia says. “He is being succeeded. It is different, and worse, and nobody makes songs about it. Which is why women write the accounts instead.”

■

She tells Prima nothing that day, and nothing the next, because a fuller is dying at the pace of water and a girl is heating honey and counting stairs so they do not count her, and because Antonia Cassia, who has waited nineteen years inside a false report of a death, can wait until a true one has had its mourning. There are debts you do not collect during a deathwatch, whatever the currency. She has written the clause somewhere herself. Between the quarters.

Chapter Sixteen

A Funeral Across the River

. . .

Vibius dies in the hour before dawn, when the city's poor do most of their important business to avoid troubling the light. The guild pays for the pyre, as the guild pays for everything the trade has first made necessary. Prima washes the body with the guildswomen, who are kind in the competent way of women who have washed everything the world produces, and lays in the shroud a needle — not his, hers; her first, blunted now to the colour of river water — because a fuller goes out of Rome in the garment he made of his life, and she was, whatever the books in whatever hands may say, his making in every way the gods inspect.

The funeral winds through Transtiberim in the rain. It rains in Rome for funerals of every class, out of fairness or habit. The baker's family walks in the position of almost-relatives, which the baker's mother discharges like a magistracy. Marcus, who has heard of the death the way he hears everything, through the plumbing, comes to stand hatless at the procession's edge in a plain cloak; he does not approach; Daphne's return of a necklace has taught him at least the outline of the lesson that grief is not an audience. Barbatus walks the whole route in the neighbourhood's ranks where he has no legal place and an entirely unchallenged one, carrying, when the bearers tire, the bier's front pole without being asked, in the manner of men who express condolence by weight.

Antonia does not come. She sends Eirene, who has buried people from every century of her own life and knows how to be present as furniture: steady, unremarked, holding what needs holding. Eirene comes back across the bridge in the evening with wet hems and a report in her filing voice. “She did her father's washing proud. The baker boy

kept hold of her elbow at the pyre like a man steadying a ladder — not taking the climb off her, just holding the ladder. I liked him for it. The mother cried where nobody could itemise it."

"And Prima?"

"Counted the guildsmen as they came past the pyre." Eirene wrings her hem into the courtyard drain with strong wrists. "Under her breath. Mouth open on the numbers. Antonia, my love, you cannot wait out of delicacy much longer. Grief makes people honest at retail. Somebody at those vats is telling that girl, tonight, with wine in them, the story of the hennaed woman. It is what funerals are for, among the poor: the redistribution of the truth."

Antonia looks up from the tax receipts, which she has been arranging for two hours in an order comprehensible only to the recently bereaved. "Tomorrow," she says. "Here. Not at the vats. I will send Barbatus with a commission urgent enough to be respectable."

"And if she's already been told, badly?"

"Then I will tell her again, well. It will not be the first thing in this city I have had to launder."

■

Lentulus hears of the fuller's death from Servilia, who tells him at the morning offering in the same tone she uses for provincial appointments, because in their house all intelligence now travels at that altitude, above the weather. "Your other — the girl across the river is burying her father today. Her father," Servilia says, correcting the sentence as a general corrects a map. "The man who raised her. I have sent, through my brother's steward, a sum to the fullers' guild for widows and orphans of the trade, unattributed. It will reach her as the world reaches people like her: late, and through institutions, and smelling faintly of somebody else's conscience."

Lentulus pours the offering. His hand — the household watches his hands at the shrine the way clients watch a banker's — does its work

without visible cost. “You might have told me you meant to send it.”

“You might have told me, at any point in nineteen years, that you had a daughter. We are even, husband, in the great Cornelian ledger. We have both been settling your youth at a distance and charging the house for the mileage.” She sets the cup in its ring. “I knew Baiae. I did not know she lived. Your father charged my ignorance as the price of my cooperation, and I paid it — I want that in whatever minutes you are keeping now, in whichever of your rooms. I married a settlement, Lentulus. I made it work the way rain makes a roof work: by finding every hole for nineteen years. Do not now make the girl into one.”

It is the longest speech of their marriage. The slaves have withdrawn at its first sentence with the drilled instincts of a household that knows which weather is for indoors. Lentulus stands at the little shrine with the Lares gleaming dully in their niche — household gods, custodians of exactly this: the sanctity of a family's arrangements — and understands that he has been forgiven nothing and condemned of very little, which in Servilia's bookkeeping is the state called *marriage*.

“What would you have me do?” he asks.

“The dowry, through the guild, as agreed with —” she does not say the name in the shrine room; names, like knives, are put away in her house after use “— as agreed. Then stay away from the girl's life with the same talent you have employed for nineteen years, but this time as a kindness she can spend. And Lentulus—” Servilia turns at the door with her veil arranged and her war over for the morning “—when Cornelia marries the Avidius boy, which she will, you will stand there like a man who has given a daughter, not settled a debt. We owe the register that much acting. It is the one tax your class still pays in full.”

Chapter Seventeen

In the Order of the Evening

. . .

She tells her in the small room off the courtyard where the linen is kept, because it is where Prima's hands will know what they are for if the rest of her forgets. There is a commission on the table — spring hangings, genuinely — and Eirene within call, and the door not quite shut, which in Antonia's house has always been a policy about conversations: nothing true here should require a lock.

Prima comes in mourning, which in Transtiberim means her best dress gone dark at the edges and her hair done by the baker's mother into an arrangement of great respectability and no mercy. She has her work-box. She has, Antonia sees at once, been told something badly already — not the thing itself, perhaps, but its approach: the averted vat-women, an old woman's funeral wine loosening the phrase *the money stopped*, the way a room changes its temperature when a girl who was *theirs in every way the gods inspect* enters it. Grief has made the neighbourhood honest at retail.

"You sent for me about spring," Prima says.

"I sent for you." Antonia sets her hands on the linen, flat, the way she tested the courtyard wall for damp on a January morning when all the year's catastrophes were still correctly unscheduled. "Prima. I am going to tell you my life. Not because you asked, and not in the order of your questions, because your questions will be better afterwards. Interrupt anyway. It is a family failing."

She tells it in the order of the evening. The house on the Quirinal. The mirror held at seventeen. A line of Greek about a woman at a loom, and a word said before it could be stopped. A young man's laugh. Teaching, and what houses call teaching when one party cannot leave them. A muster morning, a contract read upside down — *with her*

increase — stairs in Baiae, a midwife's hennaed nails, money in a sleeve, a report: *a girl, not strong*. Standing up anyway, because the alternative arithmetic did not permit standing. Freedom in a will, loans to women, two tables, a house, a name assembled from good materials with no one's permission. And then a hanging with a border of small red flowers, and a needlewoman counting with her mouth open, and thread bought across the river by a Greek who kept his face like a book.

Prima listens the way she sews: entirely, with her whole posture given over to not dropping the work. At *the money stopped* her hands go still in her lap. At *not strong* she makes a sound that she converts, with a nineteen-year-old's ferocious governance of herself, into breath. When Antonia stops, the room contains linen, light through a high window, and two women at a table with twenty years laid on it like a length of cloth awaiting the shears.

■

"The wrist," Prima says at last. She turns her left hand over. The pale mark, the half-closed eye. "My mother — my *mother* in Transtiberim — used to say it was where the goddess of the river kept her thumb on me so I wouldn't be lost. She said every kept thing has a thumbprint." She looks up. "She knew, then. All my life she was telling me in that way. And Father. *Keeping especially.* That was — he said that to me, a month ago. I thought it was the fever being fond."

"It was your father being accurate. It is the family's other failing." Antonia's voice performs its duties. Her hands remain flat on the linen, holding the cloth of the world in place by main housekeeping. "I will tell you his name too, because you are owed the whole invoice. But understand what names are in this city: his will open no door for you that your needle hasn't, and it may close several your betrothal needs. That is not my shame speaking, or his — though we both keep accounts in that currency — it is the tax office. Everything is the tax office, in the end. I have paid it for twenty years to be let alone. I propose to go on

paying it for you."

"Is it—" Prima stops. She looks toward the courtyard, where Marcus's laugh, some evenings ago, arrived ahead of him like a herald. She does the arithmetic of faces. Dark brows. A mouth open on a count. A senator's son who shared, for an instant at a doorway, something she had filed under Rome manufacturing girls. "Oh," Prima says, with a seamstress's bleak admiration for a well-hidden join. "The committee."

"The committee."

"And the boy who corrected — whom I corrected. In your dining room. About his sister."

"Your brother," Antonia says. "Half, by the law's arithmetic. Wholly, by the arithmetic your mother kept. When you told him not to talk about his sister that way — I want it in the record, since no clerk will put it there — you were the only person in Rome that evening speaking of the Cornelii as a family. Including the Cornelii."

Prima is crying now, in the way of her trade and her river: without sound, achieved at the eyes, wiped with the back of a wrist that has work to do. "I don't know what to call you."

"Antonia will do. I assembled it myself. It has held heavier." She moves then — slowly, in the order of the evening; nothing true here requires a lock, but some things require asking — and takes the girl's left hand in hers and turns it, palm up, thumb resting, for one breath, beside the pale mark rather than on it. "Your mother in Transtiberim counted stairs so they wouldn't count her. She counted you, Prima. Every day of your life, at her own rates, and the count came right. I am not arriving to re-audit her. I am arriving, late — the family opens things late — to say that the report was false, the money was a crime filed as kindness, and the daughter lived and sews better than anyone in Rome. The rest is dowry and spring hangings, and will keep until it doesn't."

Outside, the house performs its afternoon: the cook arguing with Alexandria by way of saffron, Barbatus telling the porter a story whose preamble lengthens with each telling, a dove on the tiles with its soft stupid music. Prima picks up, because her hands require it and so, she

understands, does every woman in her blood whichever riverbank filed them, the spring linen, and begins the border.

“Red flowers again,” she says, when she can. “You'd think a fine house would vary it.”

“A fine house repeats what works,” Antonia says, “and calls it taste. Show me the stitch that doesn't remember itself. I never learned. Hairdressers' daughters; we only learned to hold the mirror for other people's repairs.”

They work an hour. It is not a reconciliation, there being nothing to reconcile except the past, which does not attend meetings. It is the thing itself, which Rome, for all its Latin, has only short words for: kin, at a table, with work between them so their hands could be honest while their faces caught up.

Chapter Eighteen

Marcus Learns a Word

. . .

Marcus discovers he has a sister the way he discovers most structural facts about his family: late, loudly, and in the wrong room. The room is the baths. The instrument is a dice creditor with a cousin at the fullers' guild, where a dowry for a fuller’s daughter has just been registered in circumstances the guild's clerk described, in drink, as *Baiae money, old money, Quirinal-handled* — the three adjectives travelling, as information does, faster disreputably than clean. It reaches Marcus between the warm room and the cold plunge, unattributed, deniable, and with Prima's trade attached like a label. He stands in the plunge with the water shocking up his body and the arithmetic shocking up his mind — faces at a doorway, a correction in a dining room about a sister — *his* sister, as it transpires, twice over — and does the first adult thing of his life: he does not say it aloud in the baths.

He goes home. He finds his father alone, which the household arranges for him with a speed that tells its own story; Servilia, it develops, has been scheduling this conversation since the oysters, and intends it to happen in a room with no knives in it. The study qualifies. There are only scrolls, and the dented mirror, and three centuries looking on from the corridor.

“Is it true?” Marcus says. He has rehearsed seventeen openings between the baths and the Palatine, each more forensic than the last. This is the one that survives the doorway.

Lentulus, who has had weeks, has rehearsed one, and it deserts him even faster. He says, “Yes.”

The boy sits down without being offered the chair, which in this house is an earthquake in a minor key. “The needlewoman. Daphne's — the woman at the house. Prima.”

“Vibia Prima, of Transtiberim. Betrothed to a baker. Nineteen.” Lentulus hears himself delivering a client's particulars and makes his voice change gear, at cost. “Her father, who raised her, is a month buried. Her mother, who raised her, is two years dead. They were decent people in the way that matters.” He is quoting a dead man's tablet. Quoting is what is left when the family runs out of original sentences.

“And the other mother,” Marcus says. It is to his credit — his father notes it with a grief that has pride in it like a stone in a shoe — that he does not make it an accusation. He makes it a request for the record.

“Antonia Cassia was a slave in my father's house. She was seventeen. I was twenty-four, which my family called a mitigating factor and history should call the whole charge sheet. When she was pregnant she was sold south on a morning I was at a muster, by a father settling a marriage — your mother's and mine, Marcus; your existence is minuted in this too, which is not your fault and is now, unavoidably, your information. The child was reported dead. The report was purchased. I asked once whether there was a child, and accepted an answer in statesman's Latin because the Latin was cheaper than the truth. She lived. She sews. She corrected your manners in her mother's dining room before either of you knew why it fitted.”

Marcus is looking at his hands. They are his mother's height and his father's appetite and for once entirely still. “All winter,” he says, “you've — we've — the committee. Her *house*. You inspected her house at dawn for a province. While my — while she was sewing the border in the next room.”

“Yes.”

“Did you know then?”

“I knew nothing then that I had not taken nineteen years to avoid knowing, which is a worse sentence than the one you asked for, so I will give you the plain one: no. I opened my father's tablet in February. Your mother has known since our first month, and married the settlement anyway, and if you intend to distribute blame in this house you will find the queue forms behind your grandfather and extends through me. It

does not reach her."

"I wasn't in a queue," Marcus says. "I was at the baths." He stands up, sits down, a young man doing geometry with furniture. "Does Cornelia know?"

"No. Your sister is to be married in the summer into a family that has already surcharged us for embarrassability. She will be told —" Lentulus consults, visibly, the new ledger, the one kept between quarters "— when the telling is for her benefit and not our relief. That distinction is apparently the whole of morality. It has taken this family three hundred years to itemise it, and we owe the wording to a woman on the Caelian."

Marcus laughs once, a sound with no herald before it. "She gives good advice, that woman. *Drink your wine slowly, Marcus.* I thought she was being a hostess. She was being —" He stops at the word. They both look at it, where it stands in the room like an uninvited client at the morning hour: not *mother* (not his), not *ruin* (not anymore), not *the woman*, that bath-house filing. Something for which his education, expensive and classical, has handed him only the Greek. "She was being kin."

"Kin," Lentulus says. "Yes. It is the word your family has been avoiding at the full rate of eloquence. Learn it cheaper than I did, Marcus. That is the whole of the inheritance I can improve on your grandfather: the wording."

■

He goes to the Caelian that night — the household will report this; households report everything; that is what the plumbing is for — but he does not go in. Barbatus is at the door in his weather of a body, and Marcus, who has swept past Barbatus forty evenings through sheer pedigree, stops on the threshold as at a temple he has not been purified for.

"Is she — Prima. Is she here, working?"

“Young master,” Barbatus says, in the tone he keeps for men deciding, “the mistress's needlewoman keeps guild hours now. Mourning. And the spring work's done at her own table, at her own prices. It's an arrangement the whole street admires.”

“She's to be married.”

“To the baker. Wedding's after the mourning, guild permitting. Good family. Mother like a customs office, which in a baker means the bread's honest weight.”

Marcus stands in the doorway of his father's committee's most famous casualty, a senator's heir with a sister sewing trousseau across the river and a word newly in his pocket with Greek roots and Roman consequences. From inside comes Daphne's voice, doing, for people who know, the Greek song. “Give the house my —” he says. He cannot find a noun small enough to be true. “Tell the mistress a client of the house is learning manners. She'll know the rate.”

“I'll tell her,” Barbatus says, “the vowel sounds and all.” And watches him go down the Caelian in the spring dark at a walking pace, which for Marcus, Barbatus reflects, is as close as the young ones get to a religious procession.

Chapter Nineteen

The Borrowed Spring

. . .

Spring arrives in Rome like a rumour that turns out to be true: almond first, then the markets changing their prices and their smells, then the great column in the Forum rising drum by drum inside its scaffolding, the war spiralling up toward its own statue at a pace even the baths' plumbing can keep up with. Prima works her trousseau at her own table, at her own prices, with a dowry now inscrutably enlarged by a Baiae bequest that the baker's mother has inspected like a hem and pronounced, in the guild parlour, with deep satisfaction, *stitched straight*. The baker’s son — Titus, broad-handed, smelling permanently of warm crust, steady at ladders and pyres — holds whatever she hands him in the way of grief or linen without taking the climb off her, and Prima, who has had a winter of finding out what people are by what they do at doors, treasures the findings in order.

She goes to the Caelian on Tuesdays. Not as staff; the door-book, Diomedes has seen to it, now holds a category for *tradeswomen related by commission*, a formula of such elastic dullness that no aedile will ever measure it. They work. Sometimes they do not work and walk in the courtyard among the overwatered roses while Eirene practises, loudly, being elsewhere. Antonia tells it in pieces now, not evenings: her mother's hands in other women's hair; Baiae stairs by the counted dozen; the Naples widow whose will did the work of angels out of spite at a son-in-law; the first dining room, two tables and a lamp-seller's credit; the pastry cook's arrival, which Prima already knows by the evidence of his saffron disputes. Prima tells it back, her order: the vats, the counting, the thumbprint of the river goddess, the father who held a rail and joked. Between the two versions, on the courtyard stones, a family is being attempted the way the fullers attempt a stained garment: slowly, without

rushing the soak, in water changed as often as honesty requires.

“Does Daphne know?” Prima asks, stitching. “She looks at me now like someone reading under the line.”

“Daphne suspects an entire library. She has the singer's disease: she believes every room has a song under it. I have told her that I pay you over the rate because you are the best needlewoman in Rome. It has the virtue, in this city, of being nearly true.”

“And Marcus.” It is not quite a question. The needle goes in, comes out. “Barbatus says he came to the door and stood there like weather.”

“Marcus is learning manners at the full rate. His family does nothing by instalments except debts.” Antonia watches the border grow: red flowers, spring issue. “He will write to you, eventually. It will be a terrible letter, full of Greek, and entirely sincere. Keep it with your tools. A woman should have evidence of what men cost in their own handwriting.”

Prima laughs, and Antonia hears — files it, with Diomedes exactitude, in the third book, the real one — the sound her own laugh made at seventeen, before it was trained, in a house on the Quirinal, over a line about a loom. It does not undo her. It has, if anything, the opposite effect; the sound arrives like a sum coming right at the second count. She gets up to be about the house's business before her face can make an entry the tax office could audit.

■

At the Palatine house, spring is a calendar of bridal administration. The Avidian match is concluded — *allied*, the families will say until they die — and Servilia goes through the ceremonies of it as through a province she intends to leave better governed than she found it: the contract, the auspices, the staggering, priced choreography of two houses becoming one and pretending it is a festival rather than a merger. Cornelia assists with the dreamy competence of a girl who has decided, privately and against all the songs, that she will keep some part of the house inside

herself unregistered. She has taken, that spring, to singing the Greek one for her music master — who has been paid better, by Avidius in advance, and no longer needs to touch anyone's wrist for any reason.

On the day the contract is signed, Avidius the father lingers in Lentulus's study over Falernian that predates both their ambitions. “Your committee did you no favours in the east,” he says, harbour-fashion, stating the tide. “I lose a governor for a son-in-law's father. I gain a senator with clean hands and a new registry with his name on the clause my ships' chaplains are already quoting at the crews, may the gods restrain their enthusiasm. Overall —” the great evaluator's shrug “— I call it cargo landed. Not the manifest we filed. Landed.”

“You," Lentulus says, “are the first man to tell me that this year in that tone.”

“I unload grain. Tides waste more fortunes than storms, senator, by arriving slightly not as promised.” Avidius sets down his cup precisely in its predecessor's ring, a dockside man made good performing, perfectly, the oldest rite of the house he is marrying into. “We need not discuss the Caelian ever again in this room, I think. My son eats there less than he did, your son stands in its doorway like a penitent, and the woman who runs it has just renewed her wine contract with my partner at a price that suggests she knew the vintage before the grapes did. Rome, eh? The accounts all settle, one way or another. The only choice we get is the currency.”

Lentulus looks at him for a long moment, this former unloader who has just quoted his own dead father's final advice back to him without knowing a letter of it, and experiences a sensation his family has historically confused with indigestion: kinship, upstream, where no committee has jurisdiction. “To landed cargo,” he says, and they drink, two old Romans of entirely different manufacture, in a study full of paper.

Chapter Twenty

The Clause

. . .

The registry passes into the city's habits the way weather does: complained about, evaded at the margins, priced into everything by the second quarter. Antonia files her house — the upright hand, the fees on the day, the women's legal conditions entered like a roll of honour, which in the book's intention they are — and discovers, as she has discovered every regulation aimed at her survival since Baiae, that compliance, pursued to the point of theatre, is the best camouflage a working house can wear. The aediles' inspector returns in the spring quarter, by appointment now, and is given the pastry cook's almond cakes as a matter of administrative routine. He measures no doorway. He asks after the new stove. Rome has decided that the house on the Caelian is an institution, and Rome protects its institutions with the same energy it denies its people: totally, and without apology.

What Rome has not entirely decided is what to do with the clause. *No house to profit by a person whose refusal has no legal existence.* It was drafted, if the city only knew it, at dawn by a barber's client in a sentence — the single fully honest sentence, Antonia privately believes, of Lentulus's public career — and it passes through the courts that spring and summer like a coin through a market: cited by an advocate here, *distinguished* (that advocate's word for buried standing up) by a praetor there, ending up, as such coin does, in the purse of a freedwoman of the Subura who uses it, in September, to walk out of a lodging house near the Carinae on its proprietor, a man who had held her manumission money — *against breakages*, as his paperwork put it — for six years. She walks out with her papers, her savings and a copy of the clause made by a scribe who charges her half, the revolution coming as it does in Rome not with trumpets but with discounts.

Daphne hears the story at the baths and tells it in the small dining room with a singer's instinct for the final note. “She walked past him, they say, holding the paper like a torch.”

“Paper burns,” Antonia says. “That is why we also keep the Greek.” — meaning the banker, meaning the copies, meaning Diomedes three hands, meaning everything she has learned about survival being a filing system with a soul. She looks at Daphne, who is twenty-two and free three years and holding, these days, real stones of modest size purchased with her own fees and kept, by house advice, in the Greek's strongbox against a bad winter. “Your contract here comes up at the new year.”

“I know the date. Singers count bars.”

“Renew it at the new rate, with the clause cited in your own hand at the foot.” Antonia pushes across a tablet on which Diomedes — who has aged, this year, a full decade in the eyes, as people do who keep other people's centuries in thread drawers — has written the terms in the hand reserved for things that must look boring to survive. “Every woman in this house. One by one. If Rome is going to register us, it will register *that* in this house first.”

Daphne reads. The room is quiet. The house beyond performs its evening overture: water, linen, the pastry cook whose saffron has this week been vindicated by two separate Alexandrians. “He wrote this,” Daphne says finally. “The senator. In the committee that was supposed to close us.”

“He wrote a sentence. What it closes and opens is our business.” Antonia stands; the evening requires her in three rooms at once and she will accomplish it, as ever, by being fully in one at a time and letting the house's memory do the rest. “Sing the Greek tonight, Daphne. For people who know. I am told there are more of them every quarter.”

■

In the Forum the column has cleared the rooftops. Tourists from the provinces stand in its scaffolding's shadow with their heads back and

their mouths open, counting, exactly as Prima counts stitches. Lentulus passes it on his way from a committee — a real committee now, on aqueducts, which flows through his remaining public life at a respectable rate — and a foreman he half-knows tells him the inside stair is continuous to the top now: a man can climb inside the war, when it is dedicated, and come out above it.

He walks home the long way, past the Greek's office, where he does not call; past the Basilica, where his agent is performing confidence in two languages; up the Palatine in the cooling light, a senator of ancient lineage and diminished prospects whose name the baths now pronounce in the past tense of Syria and the present tense of one clause that law students have begun, this term, to be set to argue about. Acilius has written that Hadrian, from Athens, inquired of the clause's draftsman — *a Cornelius with a freedwoman's conscience*, the secretaries are saying, which is the kind of joke that gets a man remembered in the wrong way by the right people, or the other way, in reigns to come.

At home there is a letter half-written on his desk in Marcus's hand — Greek, terrible, sincere; his son leaves drafts like flags — addressed across the river. Lentulus does not read it. He puts a fresh sheet over it, weighs it with the dented mirror, and goes to stand a moment among the masks in the last of the light.

Choose better, his father wrote, dying, in the hand that gathered itself at the ends of lines.

“I chose worse for thirty years at the full rate,” Lentulus tells the wax, conversationally, as a man settles with his creditors in private. “The interest is the estate now. I am merely keeping it lit.” The masks say nothing. They have been saying it, eloquently, for three hundred years.

Chapter Twenty-One

A Wedding in the Morning

. . .

Cornelia marries young Avidius on an auspicious morning in the early summer, with the whole expensive machinery of a Roman wedding making its noise around her: flutes, torches at noon, nuts thrown at futures, the bride's saffron veil worn — Servilia's last act of generalship — like a banner rather than a shroud. The groom winces twice, once at the contract's Latin and once, gloriously, at his own relief. Marcus behaves. This is minuted by no one and noticed by everyone: the heir of the Cornelii is sober, attentive, kind to old women; the baths will take a week to find a sinister explanation, the truth — that he has been reading his own letter for a month and learning the cost of language — being unsuited to plumbing.

Antonia receives an account of it from three directions, as she receives everything: the door-book (guests of both houses dine on the Caelian that week and talk, as men do, in the order of the courses rather than the questions), the Greek (the dowry's settlement has released, through agents, a significance of payment toward Campanian paper), and Eirene, who has a cousin in service at the Acilii and no shame anywhere in her system.

“She sang at her own wedding breakfast,” Eirene reports. “One song. The Greek one. Her mother, they say, looked at the ceiling as if consulting an upstairs neighbour, and let her. And the Avidius boy cried where the flutes could cover it, which the cousin says is the most patrician thing she's ever seen a man do.”

“Let her,” Antonia says, tasting a sauce. “That is Servilia's whole art, according to Diomedes, who reveres her like a rival firm: knowing which instructions to be disobeyed in.” She looks across the kitchen to where Prima, installing the summer hangings, is standing on a stool with

pins in her mouth, engaged in not falling off the year's whole metaphor. "Prima. When you marry your baker — guild, mourning, and your future mother-in-law's calendar permitting — you will not have flutes at noon. The neighbours would report the household to itself."

"I shall have bread," Prima says around the pins, "at all hours. It compounds better."

"You will have," Antonia says, with the air of a woman filing something between quarters, "whatever this house can send across a river that smells of respectability and keeps like money. Which is to say: also bread. I am rich, Prima, not imaginative. The imagination in the family has always been on the stairs side."

The kitchen laughs — the whole kitchen, the pastry cook from Alexandria laughing in Greek at a Roman widow-inventing joke — and Prima, descending from the stool into the world's ordinary level, looks around at the big stove, the arguing empire of it, with an expression Antonia can read as easily as a tax receipt: *this, too, is a house where women keep things standing; we merely charge admission to the keeping, which in Rome is called every name except honest.*

■

Servilia, in the week after the wedding, does the thing no committee drafted: she calls on the Caelian. Not at dining hour. At the dead middle of the afternoon, veiled in the style women of her order wear to temples and assignations of state, with one slave who waits in the street with the chair and the family talent, bred over generations of service, for being furniture. Barbatus announces her by no name at all, in the doorway, in the voice of a man reporting weather of an imperial size: "A lady by appointment with nobody, mistress."

They sit in the small dining room, sized — Antonia decides in mid-breath — to nobody's self-regard at all: two chairs, the house's best water, a bowl of the pastry cook's least argumentative cakes. Two women of forty in a city that has arranged their lives as a diptych: the

one kept by the family like its standard in battle, the other sold by it like surplus baggage after one. Neither has ever been allowed, by the minuting habits of Rome, to be the other's contemporary. In a room, at a table, with cakes, the fact becomes sayable, the way things in this family do, by not being said.

“You gave her the clause,” Servilia says, without preamble, because preamble is for men who schedule. “My husband. For your women to cite over their contracts.”

“He gave the Senate a sentence. The house has adopted it at the usual rates.”

“My daughter sang Greek at her wedding.” Servilia selects a cake, inspects it like a minor treaty, eats it. “The whole city will decide I have lost authority. I find I have gained a daughter-in-law's family who pay musicians properly. It is the best exchange I have made since marrying the Cornelii, which the gods may file under their own irony.” She looks, then, directly — it is said in the Palatine house that Servilia's direct look has ended more this year campaigns than the prefect's office. “The girl across the river. Is she—” A search, through registers: *provided, settled,* the whole dowry of un-saying. Servilia, who has run out of quarter in which to file things, finishes the sentence like a woman, at last, in her own hand. “Is she happy in her arrangement, Antonia? Baking and hems?”

“She is stitching a life at her own prices,” Antonia says. “With a man who holds ladders. She knows what knowing is worth here and spends it in her own street. That is as close to happiness as my people file, Servilia.”

“Your people.” Servilia considers the cakes. “And mine. My son has written her a letter.”

“I advised keeping it with her tools. Evidence of what men cost, in their own handwriting.”

“It will be Greek and terrible.”

“I said so too.” Antonia, to her own extreme inconvenience, feels the sentence arrive that she has not minuted and cannot invoice. “He meant

it well. In our families —" she stops. Re-files. "That is new. That can stay."

Servilia rises. The visit has lasted exactly the length of a temple call; the slave in the street will report a temple call. At the door she looks back across the small dining room, the plain good furniture of it, the house beyond beginning its evening the way a ship begins a tide. "We were both bought, you know," she says, conversationally, as one quartermaster to another. "The currencies differed. I believe that is what my husband's clause is about, draftsman though he was of everything else. Do not let the law students explain it to you. They will make it smaller."

"Come again when the committee is forgotten," Antonia says. "The cakes improve by quarter. It is our whole fiscal policy."

"I do not make social calls I cannot describe to my household gods." Servilia arranges her veil with hands expert and, for the first time in Antonia's observation of them at shrine-distance, not quite certain of the fold. "But I may send for the recipe. Rome will call that the beginning of the end, and for once the baths will be right at their usual rate of accuracy."

Chapter Twenty-Two

Letters from Athens

. . .

The emperor will go east; that much the stone yards know, the granaries know, the letter-writers of Athens know at flattering length. Hadrian writes to Rome in the accomplished hand of a man collecting a world: architecture, cults, old friendships renewed like leases. His name goes up one side of the city's future and down the other. Syria goes — the secretaries settle it over the summer like a cloth over a table — to a safer pair of hands, a man whose private geometry contains no Caelian angles, no clauses. Lentulus receives the news from Acilius in the baths, where all great disappointments in Rome are steamed for tenderness.

"It was the clause, in the end?" Acilius asks it gently; there is a consul's kindness that consists of not requiring a man to watch his own autopsy.

"It was the appearance of a man who might, in a province, write another one." Lentulus settles into the warm water up to the ribs; the shoulder from Moesia gives its opinion in the old language. "I find I do not believe in the east anymore, Acilius. Not as a cure. My father governed provinces to keep from governing his house. The house is where the interest accrues. You may tell Athens I said something about my health."

"I shall tell Athens you are wanted on aqueducts."

"Aqueducts," Lentulus says, with feeling, "are the one public work a Cornelius can supervise where what flows downhill is only water."

He does not rage, which the household finds more alarming than rage and Servilia finds, correctly, elegiac. He takes the aqueduct work with the whole force of a disappointed competence; inside the year, two leaking arcades on the road to Praeneste will bear, in small unglamorous lettering no tourist will ever photograph with their mouth open, the

name of the curator who made the water arrive where the maps had always claimed it did. Marcus, watching his father choose maintenance over monument, writes the fifth draft of his letter, in which the Greek is suddenly half the length and the sincerity twice, and sends it across the river by Barbatus — who charges, as messenger, one new-mended cloak strap, the house's real currency — with no seal and his own name, which costs him more than any seal in the collections of his ancestors.

■

Prima reads it at her table, twice, with the baker's bread cooling beside her in rows like the Forum's columns, and then, as advised, puts it with her tools. She writes back in Latin without a single Greek word in it, four lines: that she is well; that the shop will bake for the guild feast; that he is not to give her sister Cornelia messages he lacks the standing to deliver; and that if he wishes to be *kin* — she has the word from Daphne by now, the plumbing having delivered that too, disreputably and clean — he can begin by doing nothing where her name is spoken at his family's table, noisily, for about nineteen years. “After that,” the letter ends, “we will see what the figures say. It is apparently the family poetry.”

Marcus keeps this letter in the scroll-case under his grandfather's mask, in the sticking cupboard, where sealed tablets ripen. The household, which thinks in plumbing, decides that the young master has become religious. Servilia, who knows the cupboard's exact inventory of the century, instructs no one about it at all. The masks look down. One day, Antonia reflects when the story completes its migration to the Caelian — by way of Barbatus, who tells it as a fight he once saw in which nobody died, the rarest kind he knows — one day someone will open all the cupboards of that family at once, and the smell of old wax and newer ink will describe Rome better than the column will, whatever height it reaches.

Chapter Twenty-Three

The Vintage

. . .

The vintage comes to Campania like a debt falling due: men in the rows before light, the presses, the year's whole borrowed weather turned suddenly, crushingly, into fact. Antonia goes south in the autumn on the Greek's business that is her business — an investor is entitled to inspect an olive grove, indeed to taste its grievances — travelling with Diomedes and a mule-driver whose opinions on emperors would constitute treason in any province not hardened by long exposure to mule-drivers. She has not been back to Baiae in twenty-one years. The road insists on reminders the way roads do: a hillside town climbed by steps; a well-dressed girl at a fountain holding, steady as a standard, a tray that is absolutely a mirror.

He is there because the vintage requires owners as well as creditors, and because the Greek, who has survived forty years by arranging rooms, has arranged for once a grove. Lentulus among his olives looks less like a senator than like a man auditing trees that have read his family's accounts for three centuries and remain, professionally, unimpressed. The agent does the talking. The Greek does the not-talking, in two languages. Antonia walks the terraces with the business end of her mind uppermost — drainage (poor, old the Roman way), trees (good), press (a disgrace she is already pricing) — and understands, with the part of her the business is protecting, that she has brought herself to this ground on purpose. The eyes do it, eventually. Cities can be filed. Ground cannot. This is her money's ground now, a useful share of it. It is also, in a book no Greek keeps, the ground she was sold south *from*: the muster, the contract, the south itself like a direction on a coffin.

“The press wants replacing before next year,” she says, because she came to say things that could be minuted. “Whoever holds the paper after this vintage should insist on it, or the yield will file its own report.”

“The marriage has paid the Greek's first significance.” Lentulus picks an olive, not ripe, and puts it in his mouth anyway, either from habit or penance; the bitterness crosses his face like weather. “The remainder — you are being paid, Antonia. At the full rate. I wanted you to hear the estate say so with its mouth full.”

“I hear quarterly. It is my civic religion; you may have read of it.” She looks down the terraces to where the sea does its old indifferent glitter, Baiae-ward. “I climbed stairs down there for two years with water that weighed more than I did, by the end of the summers. I own paper on your trees now. If a poet of my acquaintance wrote it he'd be sent back to the kitchen for saffron abuse.”

■

“I have thought—” he begins, and stops, because what he has thought has taken him nine months to come down to this terrace to say without a committee to hold it. The presses groan below. A overseer's whistle, somebody's laugh, doves. “I have thought a man should be able to apologise in the order of the evening, too. Not the questions. Yours would be unanswerable at my rates.”

“Then in the order of the evening,” Antonia says, and folds her hands, and lets him.

He tells it. The muster. The study smelling of wax. The question asked once; the statesman's sentence accepted; twenty years marching with a stone in the shoe and calling the limp a style. He tells it without the Senate in it, which for Lentulus is nakedness beyond any baths. He does not say the word *love* because they are forty and the word has been taxed out of their bracket; he says *I let my father choose the currency*, which in Cornelian is the same confession with the ancestry left in.

Antonia listens the way she listens to men after the fish course: for the truth under the arrangement. It is there. It has the unsatisfying shape of truth, which does not unlock rooms or unclimb stairs. It merely stops charging interest at the moment of its payment, and not an hour before.

“You were twenty-four,” she says at last. “I have Marcus's measure now; I know what your family's twenty-four is worth in the market. I was seventeen and *unpaid*, which is a different currency, and no apology is legal tender for it anywhere in this empire. So we will not pretend. The money is settled quarterly. The girl is settled better than money. The clause —” she pauses, and finds, to her housekeeping soul's surprise, something approaching warmth available, unbolted, between the quarters “— the clause is walking about Rome in other women's hands, Lentulus, doing what no apology of yours could stock. If a Cornelius must pay his debts, I will let the record show he paid in infrastructure.”

“Aqueducts and adverbs,” he says, with the first unguarded smile she has seen on him since a courtyard she does not visit. “My grandfather is revolving in his mask.”

“Your grandfather is filing it. Masks can't move; that's their whole tragedy and your family's business model.” She turns back toward the presses, the agent, the Greek's beautiful silences. “Replace the press, Lentulus. Your olives deserve machinery that isn't a metaphor. So, if we are itemising, do your children. All —” she lets the plural stand on the terrace in the autumn light — at length, in the open, between the press and the sea “— of them.”

They walk down between the trees at a proprietor's pace, two Romans in early middle age with a shared minority holding in each other's ruin and a settlement, finally, in the only currency that has ever cleared in this city: work done on the ground, in season, by name.

Chapter Twenty-Four

What the Column Shows

. . .

They dedicate the column the following May, and Rome, which has watched it climb for two years inside its scaffolding, receives the reveal the way it receives everything imperial: by first applauding the emperor and then, having discharged glory, getting on with the serious business of trying to read it. The frieze goes up and up in its spiral: bridges, camps, battles, surrenders, the emperor addressing, the emperor sacrificing, the emperor — carved at intervals close enough that a man at ground level can keep finding him like a heartbeat — while all around him the war happens to other, smaller people, who carry and build and burn and are carried. From the courtyard you can read the beginning and the high middle blurs. For the rest you would need to be a bird, or the architect, or dead and put up there in a pot of gold at the top, as they say the emperor's ashes will be: the one reader of his own war with a perfect view being history, which in Rome means property.

Antonia stands in the same margin she stood in for the Forum's dedication, veiled respectably, the purple-dealer still making room out of an old debt now refinanced by gratitude. But the company has reorganised itself around her the way water reorganises around a stone it has decided to keep. Eirene is at her elbow. Prima — married since the winter, in a baker's wife's good wool with her tools' dowry half converted to a share in the bakehouse oven — stands at the other, at a distance that family keeps in a crowd full of aediles: close enough for history, far enough for paperwork. Marcus, who has taken to being civil in public forums with the concentration of a man defusing his own youth, inclines his head to the party from across the contractor's wives with a discretion that costs him visibly and is therefore, by every moral the city runs on, nearly worth something. The baker Titus holds Prima's

elbow the way men hold ladders, and looks up at the imperial spiral with his mouth open, counting.

“What can you see?” Prima asks him.

“The beginning. And men with baskets. There's always the men with baskets, if you look where the emperor isn't.”

Antonia looks where the emperor isn't. She is good at it; it has been her civic religion's other service. In the carved crowd at the column's base the stone has them all: auxilia in their foreign trousers, engineers, women with bundles at the edges of camps, the whole freight of an empire moving on the backs the inscription will not name. She thinks of the names in Diomedes third book, wax renewed quarterly so some histories melt; of a fuller and his wife keeping a child after the paying stopped being the reason; of a woman in the Subura reading a Claudian clause aloud to a lodging-house door; of every *unpaid* person holding the mirror steady at seventeen while the carving was done elsewhere. Rome will read this column the way it reads everything: from the bottom, getting tired. She does not hold it against the stone. Stone is only as honest as the height you let people read it from.

Across the courtyard, in the lane that opens for them, the senators pass: Acilius, consular, benign; Postumus, telling a story to a priest's chin-strap; and Lentulus, in wool that still costs more than a horse, with Servilia beside him in grey that costs more than the horse's opinions. He does not look for Antonia. It is still a discipline. But as the lane closes he does something that only three people in the crowd can read — one of them baked this morning, one of them keeps three sets of books, and the third counts stitches with her mouth open — he touches, briefly, two fingers to the edge of his toga where the old scar's mirror-image would sit, under the left ear: not a sign, not a signal, only a man feeling for a fact on his own skin in a public place. Felix always leaves the scar. Some men like to think the decision is fresh every morning. He is not one of them anymore. The lane closes.

■

That evening the house on the Caelian is full in its ordinary extraordinary way. The column's shadow, two hills away, is at that hour complimenting everything. Daphne sings a new song — Greek verses, a Roman setting, about a woman at a loom — and in the last stanza the faithful wife does the thing the poets have never yet permitted her: she presents her husband, home from the war at last, with the accounts. It gets the laugh and then it gets the silence, which in Antonia's room is the more expensive response. Men of business look into their cups. Someone says it will never play in the theatres, and Philomela, who has taken to harmony the way praetors take to *distinguishing* things, says that is because the theatres only sing the first frieze of everything, darling, the part where the emperor is still legible.

Antonia moves through the rooms. The damp has not come through the courtyard wall this spring: a new drain, Cornelian-supervised, aqueduct-adjacent, invoice impeccable, sees to it. Diomedes books, in the second hand now more often than the first, total themselves with less arguing. The house will be registered, taxed, inspected by appointment, and let alone, which in Rome is the compound noun *peace*. At the hour when the guests begin to be steered, waterproofed, toward litters and back streets, Barbatus brings a folded message with no seal, and stands looking at it in his fist like a man who has finally been handed the last of a kind.

It is from Prima. — *The shop has the guild feast. We will want the big room's hanging for the bakery door that day, if the house can lend what I sewed it. The child will be born by harvest, Titus says, who knows about rising. If it's a girl she will be taught letters before thread. If it's a boy, thread first, then letters, so he knows what the letters cost.* At the foot, in the writing that Barbatus taught no one and Daphne taught her half of: *I count everything so it doesn't count me. We're even, nearly. Which in the family, I'm told, is a kind of fortune.*

Antonia stands in the doorway of the great dining room, where the hanging in question draws its red border round the evening. Eirene, passing with the lamps, says nothing, having spent thirty years learning

the precise weight of that currency. Antonia folds the message once — precisely, as she has folded others, between the quarters of the tax receipts where all the important correspondence of her life has been filed since a young man taught her, among other thefts, the letter that begins her name. “Tell Barbatus,” she says, “the house will bring the hanging itself on the morning. By the front street. In a cart with ribbons, if the pastry cook's nephew can be trusted with colours.”

The lamps go up. The city does its night shift: bakers and fullers and clerks and column-carvers sleeping the sleep of the unnamed. Tomorrow there will be registrations, favourable winds for Avidian grain, a leaking arcade on the Praeneste road acquiring small unglamorous lettering, a wedding or a funeral or a girl with a mirror learning to read over somebody's shoulder the exact words that will one day be the beginning of her. Rome is the mistress of the known world, says the inscription programme. It is also, says the house, settling its accounts by lamplight, quarterly, in three hands, a fuller’s daughter at either end of it, holding.

Chapter Twenty-Five

Every Favour a Debt

. . .

A year is not an ending. Rome disapproves of endings; it has aqueducts instead. Things arrive where the maps claimed they did, late, by gravity and maintenance, and the city drinks without inquiring into the small unglamorous lettering. But a house keeps its own calendar. A house counts from the morning the damp came through a wall in the shape of a country it had never been to, and from an inspection notice left before dawn, and from the sound — still the truest minute Antonia owns, more reliable than any portent the colleges sell — of a needle going in, and coming out, and the flowers along a border learning how to be the same and not the same.

So let the record, in whichever hand survives the quarter, close the books on the following. The child across the river is born by harvest, a girl, in the lean-to room above the vats where frankly so much of the century was laundered. She is called, after business in the family that the baker's mother calls respect and Daphne calls orchestration, Lucia Vibia — the river first, the light before it, paperwork after a decent interval — and she has a thumbprint, if a person were fanciful, on the inside of one wrist, and she will be taught letters before thread by women competing on the point like rival firms. The bakehouse flourishes at the rate of honest weight. The hanging with the red flowers goes back and forth across the bridges on feast days until the neighbourhood begins to date things by it, which is how traditions, like debts, acquire the patina of having been inevitable.

Marcus goes, at summer's end, as a junior officer to an eastern staff, not his father's war, which has gone to safer hands, but a real one, with baskets. He writes home in Latin of steadily improving plainness. From Antioch he writes once to Transtiberim: three lines, no Greek beyond a

place-name, and an unsuitable present of writing tablets for a niece not yet born when he sent them, which Prima puts with her tools, evidence admissible at last. Cornelia, from a house that no longer leaks into the dining room, becomes the Avidii's connection to every singer in Rome worth paying properly, and corresponds — through the house's careful channels, at the usual rates of sororal paperwork — with a needlewoman of remarkable hems whose trousseau work her household commissions above the market. The letter in which she first guesses why is never sent. Servilia, who has scheduled everyone else's acts of this drama for nineteen years, sends instead, on the suitable feast, a recipe request. It comes back copied in Diomedes second hand, the one things live in. The pastry cook, learning that Servilia has made his almond cakes for a committee of aqueduct widows, takes to calling himself the pastry cook to two empires, and has to be sat on, kindly and specifically, by both.

Lentulus grows older the way his family goes into decline: with great dignity and improved water pressure. His name is spoken in baths, as steam; it is carved, also, in small letters where things work. Hadrian comes home from Athens and the future clanks gently up the Palatine in Greek dress; the emperor goes east to his war at last, to the drum-rolls of the stone yards, and the old men who stayed behind to mind the city's plumbing find themselves, to their discreet surprise, in something resembling favour. It lifts nobody to a column. It keeps the fountains running. Lentulus, inspecting an arcade in the second spring, is heard by an engineer to say that history is mostly maintenance and the rest is scaffolding. The engineer, who wears foreign trousers and has read exactly the legible part of the frieze, reports this in the baths as philosophy. It does the rounds. It reaches the Caelian in the door-book version by noon.

■

And the house. Let the record show the house. Registered, taxed, inspected by appointment, its women signing their contracts with a

clause in their own hands at the foot — Daphne first, in letters big enough for auditors, Philomela with a flourish praetors would call distinguishing. The library of *names* the city is convinced it keeps, it keeps exactly as it ever kept them: in Antonia's memory, unminuted, ageing like wine rather than wax. What has changed, if the aediles cared to measure a doorway they no longer measure, is that the house has begun to be described at dinners as respectable. Antonia treats the word the way her house treats glass jewellery: she acknowledges the intention and returns it beautifully. Respectability is a lane that opens. She has spent twenty-one years learning how lanes close. She will take the peace and keep the paperwork.

On the last evening this record keeps — for houses, like columns, must declare a dedication date somewhere, or the scaffolding never comes down — the lamps are being trimmed, Diomedes is failing, on purpose, to notice Eirene correcting his Greek by ear, Barbatus is telling the night porter a story whose dishonest preamble has achieved its final, perfected length, and Antonia Cassia, who was born with nothing worth the law's remembering, stands in her own courtyard with her hand flat to a wall that has stayed dry a full year along a drain whose lettering nobody will ever read. From the great room, the sound of women counting — stitches, bars, coins, stairs — comes as it has always come in this house, under the music, like the true plumbing.

In Rome, every favour creates a debt. She has made a life, and a house, and — in the third set of books, the real one, filed between the quarters among unsigned notes and one folded message about ribbons — a family, out of knowing to the last figure what the debts were. Every secret carries a price: she has paid hers in the only coin that kept its value in the getting, which was work, done on the ground, in season, by name. And the past, however carefully buried —— the past came back across a bridge one Tuesday at a time with a work-box, and sat in the courtyard, and counted with its mouth open, and asked for nothing but thread at its own prices.

She takes her hand off the wall. The plaster is warm now, evening-warmed, hers. Somewhere across the river a child is being counted to sleep. Somewhere on the Palatine an old man is choosing, nightly, at compound interest, better. In the Forum, above them all, a stone war climbs toward a pot of gold ashes and the one perfect view; and at its foot, unregarded, the men with baskets hold up, as they always have, the legible beginning of everything.

“The books are straight,” Diomedes says from the doorway, in the second hand, the one for things that must look boring to survive.

“Then we are even, nearly,” Antonia said. “In this city that's a fortune. Put the lamps up. Rome is coming to dinner.”

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The End